



CITY: Pg 3

The great drain gain:
Over 90% desilted



NATION: Pg 5

MEA says 75 years of India-Japan
ties to be celebrated in 2027



FILM: Pg 12

Aamir Khan to marry Gauri Spratt
on July 5 at his Mumbai home

3 KILLED IN HIMACHAL

Monsoon advances
across north India
as Centre reviews
drought threat



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The southwest monsoon advanced further across northern India on Friday, bringing widespread rain to several states, triggering waterlogging, road closures and three rain-related deaths in Himachal Pradesh, even as the Centre reviewed concerns over below-normal rainfall and possible drought conditions in parts of the country due to the El Nino effect. Union Home Minister Amit Shah chaired a high-level meeting with Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and senior officials, directing central ministries to remain vigilant, coordinate with states and guide farmers on kharif sowing amid the weak monsoon.

According to an official statement, Shah said the government was "continuously monitoring the situation regarding below-normal rainfall and potential drought conditions in certain parts of the country due to El Nino." He asked the agriculture ministry

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Centre orders removal of
three Chinese apps used to
remotely disable e-vehicles

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre has directed app stores to remove three Chinese mobile applications, BAT-BMS, Lossyig and Epoch-i-ion, after they were allegedly misused to remotely disable battery-operated vehicles in India, official sources said on Friday amid rising concerns over cybersecurity risks in connected mobility systems.

The action follows the circulation of several social media videos showing electric rickshaws being rendered inoperable through the BAT-BMS application. The clips raised concerns over third-party apps gaining access to critical battery functions and the security measures built into battery management systems used in electric vehicles.

According to government sources, the three applications were found to have been misused to remotely disable battery-operated vehicles. Authorities have also decided to block any other application found facilitating similar misuse. The government is in touch with app marketplace operators to prevent the distribution of applications that could pose cybersecurity risks.

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'If you have FIRs, switch
sides, there is a washing
machine': Bombay HC

Says Citizens not slaves of govt,
can't be externed merely for tak-
ing part in protests against it

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Bombay High Court has quashed a one-year externment order issued against a local political leader in Maharashtra, holding that participating in protests against the government cannot by itself justify such action under the law. The court said citizens cannot be treated as "slaves of the government" for expressing dissent and observed that penal action taken solely for opposing government decisions violates the constitutional guarantees of free speech and dignity. During the hearing, the court also made a series of oral remarks on the state's political climate, joking that the petitioner could consider switching political parties because of the ongoing "horse trading" in Maharashtra and the existence of a political "washing machine" that could make criminal cases disappear.

Justice Madhav Jamdar was hearing a petition filed by Saeed Ahmad Abdul Wahid Chaudhary, 49, general secretary of the Social Democratic Party of India (SDPI), challenging the externment order passed against him by the Maharashtra Police.

The court set aside the December 3, 2025 order issued by the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Zone 6, and the March 27, 2026 appellate order of the Divisional Commissioner, Konkarn Division. The orders had

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ANTI-DRONE SYSTEMS, MRSAM, KAMIKAZE DRONES

Centre clears Rs 52,000 cr defence
procurement push for armed forces

MAJOR PROCUREMENT PUSH FOCUSES ON INDIGENOUS TECHNOLOGY,
MULTI-LAYERED AIR DEFENCE AND NETWORK-CENTRIC WARFARE

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: With modern warfare increasingly shaped by drones, precision-guided weapons and advanced air defence systems, the Defence Ministry on Friday approved capital acquisition proposals worth about Rs 52,000 crore to strengthen the operational capability of the armed forces. The Defence Acquisition Council (DAC), chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, accorded Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for a range of indigenous systems for the Army, Navy and Air Force.

The approvals are aimed at enhancing India's preparedness against emerging battlefield threats while boosting the induction of domestically developed defence equipment.

For the Indian Army, the DAC cleared procurement of the Anti-Unmanned Aerial Vehicle (UAV) Electronic Warfare System 'Akash Tarang', Man Portable Anti-Tank



Guided Missile (MPATGM) systems, Medium Range Surface-to-Air Missile (MRSAM) weapon system, Very Short Range Air Defence System (V-SHORADS), Active Protection System (APS)

for tanks and a jet-based kamikaze drone system.

The Akash Tarang system is designed to detect, track, jam and disrupt hostile drones used for surveillance, reconnaissance and

precision strikes. It is expected to provide protection to military bases, strategic assets, critical infrastructure and border areas against the growing threat posed by unmanned

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HIGHLIGHTS

- » Approvals cover indigenous systems for Army, Navy and Air Force
- » Army to procure Akash Tarang anti-UAV electronic warfare system
- » MPATGM systems approved to strengthen infantry anti-tank capability
- » MRSAM weapon system approved to bolster air defence
- » V-SHORADS procurement cleared for frontline air defence
- » Active Protection Systems approved to enhance tank survivability
- » Army to induct jet-based kamikaze drone systems
- » Navy to procure Multi Influence Ground Mines
- » Naval Shipborne Unmanned Aerial Systems receive procurement approval

RAM TEMPLE DONATION 'THEFT'

SIT to re-audit trust's accounts for past five
years; Varanasi security agency under scanner

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA (UP): The Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged embezzlement of devotees' donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya will conduct a fresh audit of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust's accounts covering the last five years after its preliminary inquiry pointed to large-scale financial irregularities, sources said on Friday.

As the investigation expands, the SIT is also examining the role of a Varanasi-based private security agency that supplied person-



nel for cash handling and security duties at the temple. Six of the eight people arrested so far were employed by the agency, prompting investigators to look into the recruitment process, background verification and possible adminis-

trative lapses.

They were deployed at the temple following a recommendation from officials of the SBI branch in Ayodhya

According to sources, the re-audit will examine expenditure related to the temple's construction as well as gold, silver and jewellery received as donations. Investigators will scrutinise the Trust's

financial records for the entire five-year period to identify any discrepancies.

The SIT also questioned key accused Avinash Shukla after taking him into police custody. Shukla, who was engaged in donation-counting work at the temple, had been arrested earlier in the case. A local court granted his police custody for 24 hours on Thursday.

Police sources said the largest cash recovery in the case so far has been made from Shukla, and legal proceedings against him have intensified.

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No change in India's stand on
Indus Waters Treaty: MEA

India says 1960 pact will remain suspended until
Islamabad credibly ends cross-border terrorism

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Friday reiterated that there has been no change in its position on the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT), saying the 1960 agreement with Pakistan will remain in abeyance until Islamabad takes credible steps to end its support for cross-border terrorism.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) issued the response after Pakistan renewed its objections to India's decision. Pakistan's Climate Change Minister Musadik Malik warned that Islamabad would "cut off those hands" that sought to claim Pakistan's share of water, while Information Minister Attaulah Tamar maintained that

the World Bank-brokered treaty remains legally binding and cannot be suspended or amended unilaterally.

Addressing the weekly media briefing, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, "India's stand regarding the Indus Waters Treaty is unchanged. The treaty remains in abeyance for Pakistan's support to cross-border terrorism. We will urge Pakistan to abjure promoting cross-border terrorism."

India suspended the treaty after the Pahalgam terror attack, maintaining that cross-border terrorism and bilateral cooperation cannot go hand in hand. Prime Minister Narendra Modi had earlier said that "blood and water cannot flow together."

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PROPOSES CRIMINAL ACTION AGAINST DOPING FACILITATORS

Centre plans tougher anti-doping law

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre is preparing to amend the National Anti-Doping Act to bring organised doping activities under criminal law, marking a major shift in India's approach to tackling performance-enhancing drugs. The proposed amendments, expected to be introduced during the Monsoon Session of Parliament beginning July 20, will focus on dismantling the supply chains behind doping by targeting traffickers, suppliers, coaches, support staff and others involved in procuring or administering banned substances. The move comes as India continues to top the Athletics Integrity Unit's (AIU) global list of doping offenders and faces

CLOSER LOOK

- » Organised doping activities to attract criminal prosecution
- » Athletes testing positive alone will not face criminal charges
- » Focus shifts to suppliers, traffickers, coaches and support staff
- » Trafficking banned substances may invite up to five years' imprisonment



- » Draft amendments were released for public consultation
- » Consultation period ended on June 18
- » India tops AIU sanctions list with 162 offenders

growing international scrutiny over its anti-doping programme.

The Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports has already placed the draft amendments in the public

domain for stakeholder consultation. The consultation period ended on June 18.

According to officials familiar with the proposal, athletes will not

face criminal prosecution merely for testing positive or committing Anti-Doping Rule Violations (ADRVs). Instead, sporting sanctions such as suspensions and disqualifications under the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) framework will continue to apply unless an athlete is found to be directly involved in offences such as trafficking or organised criminal activity.

"The objective is to break the organised supply chain behind doping rather than criminalise athletes who are already subject to sporting sanctions," a government source said.

The proposed amendments seek to criminalise trafficking, illegal sale and distribution of prohibited

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NOTICE TO SEEK EXPLANATION

Centre to summon Meta on
Instagram ads promoting
child sexual abuse material

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre is set to issue a notice to Meta after Information Technology Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw directed officials of the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) to summon the company over allegations that Instagram carried advertisements promoting child sexual abuse material (CSAM). The move marks the second time this week that the social media giant has come under regulatory scrutiny from the government.

Government sources said the ministry will seek a detailed explanation from Meta and ask what action it has taken following allegations that advertisements linked to child sexual abuse material appeared on Instagram. The notice is also expected to seek details of the safeguards the company plans to introduce to prevent such incidents in the future.

The action follows a BBC investigation that alleged Meta's recommendation algorithm promoted videos containing child sexual abuse material, exposing serious shortcomings in its content safety systems. The report also claimed that advertisements carrying terms such as "rape video" and "child video" appeared on Facebook and Instagram, despite Meta's advertising policies banning nudity and sexually explicit content.

According to the report, the advertisements directed users to Telegram channels where such illegal content was allegedly being sold.

A person familiar with the matter said the government wants Meta to explain how such advertisements were approved for publication and what corrective measures have been taken since the allegations surfaced.

Sources said Meta cannot rely on the argument that

KEY POINTS

- » Notice will ask how such advertisements received approval
- » Government seeks details of corrective measures and future safeguards
- » BBC alleged Meta algorithm promoted child sexual abuse material videos
- » Report claimed Facebook and Instagram carried illegal paid advertisements
- » Ads allegedly redirected users to Telegram channels selling abusive content
- » Sources said Meta cannot cite third-party content defence for paid ads
- » Platforms earning ad revenue may face accountability if allegations are proven

the content was posted by third parties if the allegations involve paid advertisements.

"If the allegations are found to be true, they will be held accountable for the advertisements, for which the platform receives revenue," a source said.

While MeitY will examine the technical and regulatory aspects of the issue, sources noted that any agency, authority or individual can also file complaints against the advertiser or the platform if they believe offences under the law have been committed.

Meta did not respond to queries on the proposed government action.

Responding earlier to the BBC report, a Meta spokesperson said the company follows a zero-tolerance policy against child sexual abuse material, including in advertisements.

"We use advanced AI technology to proactively detect violating content and individuals, but we

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A NATION IN MOURNING



Mourners gather around the coffin of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran

AP/PTI

UIDAI enables free email
update via Aadhaar App

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The UIDAI has enabled free email update facility directly through its new app for Aadhaar holders without the need to visit any centre, according to an official statement issued on Friday.

This is a free service via the Aadhaar app only, effective July 1, 2026 for a period of six months, making it easier for residents to keep their Aadhaar information up to date, the statement said.

"The Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) has allowed people to add or update their email ID in Aadhaar directly through the Aadhaar App,

eliminating the need to visit an Aadhaar centre.

Within two days of the new service available on the Aadhaar App, more than 250,000 people have updated their email addresses, the statement said.

"Linking email with Aadhaar helps in receiving real-time email notifications whenever an Aadhaar authentication request is executed. It enhances transparency and provides an additional layer of security by enabling Aadhaar number holders to stay informed about the use of their Aadhaar for any purpose," it said.

The new mobile application of Aadhaar has crossed 31 million

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ALIPUR AREA

Speeding goods tempo crash claims three lives

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Three people were killed in the Alipur area after the driver of a speeding goods tempo allegedly dozed off and rammed into a flyover pillar, an official said on Saturday. The impact left the vehicle heavily damaged, trapping the occupants inside the cabin.

Police said the accident took place near the Bakoli bus stand in the outer north of Delhi's Alipur, when the vehicle was travelling towards Mukarba Chowk.

The deceased were identified as Jagdish Singh (50), Yashwant Singh (27), a resident of Nathupura, and Sumit (27), police said, adding that all three were residents of Delhi.

According to police, a PCR call about the accident was received around 4:30 am on Thursday, following which teams from Alipur police station rushed to the spot.

Police said rescue personnel used hydraulic equipment to cut open the mangled cabin and remove the two occupants trapped inside. Another injured man had already been shifted by ambulance to Satyawadi Raja Harish Chandra Hospital in Narela, police said.

The injured were taken to the hospital, where doctors declared all three brought dead, police said. Their bodies were

Two pedestrians injured by speeding car in GGM

GURUGRAM: A speeding Baleno car struck two people standing on the roadside in Sector 75 on Southern Peripheral Road (SPR) on Thursday morning and sped away, leaving the victims flung into the air before crashing to the ground, writhing in pain, officials said. Police said a video of the incident went viral on social media.

The critically injured, including a graphic designer, were admitted to a hospital and are not yet fit to give a statement, they said, adding that an FIR was registered at Badshahpur police station.

Police said on Friday an injured person lodged a complaint stating that on Thursday at 6:10 am, he was standing near the HP Petrol Pump close to the SPR traffic signal.

During that time, the driver of a blue Maruti Baleno car, driving at high speed and in a rash and negligent man-



ner, hit him, causing injuries to his legs and other parts of his body, the injured man said.

According to police, Shankar Singh, a graphic designer from Noida, who was standing by the roadside and waiting for a friend, was injured in the incident.

Police said the victims were sitting near a green belt when a speeding Baleno with a temporary registration number hit them. The three occupants briefly stopped before fleeing. An FIR has been registered, and CCTV footage is being examined to trace the accused. MPOST

later sent for a postmortem.

Initial investigation suggests that the driver may have

dozed off, leading to the crash. Police said further investigation is underway.

Cops recover 604 stolen phones worth ₹1.5 crore

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested three alleged members of a theft syndicate in connection with the theft of Vivo smartphones worth crores that were being transported to an Amazon facility, recovering 604 handsets valued at around Rs 1.5 crore.

The accused — Pan-kaj alias Dhirender, Anand alias Kudresh and Mohit alias Pundir, all residents of Uttar Pradesh — were arrested after an e-FIR was registered at Sector 23 Police Station in Dwarka on June 20 following a complaint by a



warehouse manager.

Police said around 4,500 Vivo smartphones had been loaded onto a truck for delivery to Gurugram. During transit, the driver allegedly conspired with associates to steal nearly 1,500 handsets before abandoning the vehi-

cle with the remaining consignment and fleeing.

A special investigation team examined footage from more than 200 CCTV cameras, leading investigators to a pickup vehicle allegedly used to transport the stolen phones.

Acting on production warrants, Delhi Police arrested the trio and, based on their disclosures, recovered 604 concealed smartphones from a garden in Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh. Police suspect the accused were involved in similar thefts across several states. Further investigation is underway.

‘Delhiites to get Yamuna cruise after monsoon’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhiites will be able to enjoy an international-standard cruise on the Yamuna after the monsoon season, while the city is also developing a Religious Tourism Circuit to boost tourism, Delhi Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra announced on Friday.

Speaking at the inauguration of the 35th Annual Mango Festival at Dilli Haat, Janakpuri, Mishra said Delhi was being transformed from a transit city into a major tourist destination. He added that double-decker sightseeing buses had been introduced and the Delhi Darshan bus service revived to improve access to key attractions and enhance the visitor experience.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated the three-day festival, which features more than 400 varieties of mangoes from across India. She described mangoes as a symbol of India's cultural identity and said the festival showcases the country's rich agricultural diversity. Visitors can enjoy mango-eating contests, cultural performances, handicrafts, food stalls and purchase fresh mangoes, processed products and saplings. The festival, organised by the Delhi Tourism Department, will remain open daily from noon to 9 pm until July 5.

Affordable plot scheme in Noida Airport region

DIPIKA KIROLA

NEW DELHI: The Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) is preparing to launch an affordable residential plot scheme near the upcoming Noida International Airport, with around 3,800 plots of 40 square metres planned for economically weaker and lower-income families across three sectors in Yamuna City.

The authority has begun drafting an action plan for the phased rollout as rising property prices in the airport region make home ownership increasingly difficult for low-income households. YEIDA has revised

its earlier proposal of offering 30-square metre plots after technical scrutiny found the smaller size did not meet prevailing building by-laws and construction norms in the National Capital Region. The authority is also considering increasing the annual income eligibility limit from Rs 3 lakh to Rs 8 lakh to widen access to the scheme, though the proposal is yet to be approved.

Separately, the Noida Authority generated Rs 666 crore through the e-auction of two group housing plots in Sector 151, with VRC Construction Ltd and Godrej Properties Ltd emerging as the highest bidders.

NEW NORMS EASE FUNDING FOR COMMERCIAL CHARGING STATIONS

DERC tweaks regulation for EV charging infra expansion

NEW DELHI: Power regulator DERC has cleared a major regulatory hurdle, paving the way for faster expansion of EV charging infrastructure in the national capital under the PM E-DRIVE scheme, and ensuring that new charging facilities are funded through the subsidy rather than being recovered from consumers, officials said on Friday.

Under the existing Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (Supply Code and Performance Standards) Regulations, demand notes for low-tension electricity connections of up to 200 kW included only service line and

development charges, security deposit and road restoration charges, they said.

The cost of upstream infrastructure, such as distribution transformers, high- and low-tension cables, circuit breakers, alternating current boxes, distribution boxes and protection equipment, was borne by discoms as part of their Aggregate Revenue Requirement (ARR), with the expenditure ultimately recovered through electricity tariffs paid by consumers, officials said.

These components are part of the EV public charging stations, battery charging stations and battery swapping stations.

Court orders FIR against 2 Delhi University professors over research publication fraud

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has directed the registration of an FIR against three persons, including two associate professors affiliated with the University of Delhi, over allegations of cheating, forgery and supplying fake research publication certificates.

Hearing a complaint filed by former Bharati College assistant professor Ankita Kilsen, Judicial Magistrate Gaurav Katariya said the allegations disclosed prima facie cognisable offences requiring a detailed police investigation.

In an order dated July 1, the court said, "What makes an act criminally liable is the presence of a fraudulent intention behind it. In this case, such an intention appears evident from the very outset. The alleged making of a false document.... points to a dishonest and fraudulent state of mind on the part of all three accused."

The court directed the Station Head Officer (SHO) of Shalimar Bagh police station



to register an FIR based on the complaint filed on November 5, 2024, and submit a compliance report within 30 days.

The accused named in the complaint are Sanjeev Kumar, who allegedly posed as a senior medical officer at AIIMS, associate professor at Dyal Singh College Pramod Kumar, and associate professor at Bharati College Luke Khanna.

According to the complaint, Sanjeev Kumar introduced the complainant to the two professors in 2021 on the assurance that they would help her secure an assistant professor's position. The complainant alleged that the two professors persuaded her to pay Rs 1 lakh in cash as publication charges and

“The alleged making of a false document.... points to a dishonest and fraudulent state of mind on the part of all three accused”

travel expenses, and collected her original research papers, promising to publish them in reputed academic journals.

She claimed that photocopies of three purportedly published research papers and publication certificates were later handed over to her, which she relied upon while applying for teaching positions.

The complainant was appointed as an assistant professor in the Department of Political Science at Bharati College in November 2023.

However, in August 2024, the college informed her that an RTI inquiry had revealed the research publications submitted by her were allegedly fake. She was later served a show-

cause notice and her services were terminated in October 2024 after an inquiry committee concluded that the three publications were not genuine.

The complainant further alleged that one of the accused later demanded Rs 25 lakh to "settle" the matter and ensure that she retained her job. She was represented by advocate Pardeep Khatri, assisted by advocate Pranjal Bhaskar.

An action taken report filed by the police had earlier termed the dispute civil in nature and stated that no cognisable offence was made out.

Rejecting the police's conclusion, the court held that the material placed on record disclosed a prima facie case warranting investigation.

"The supply and use of what are alleged to be forged certificates of publication to secure a government appointment constitutes a prima facie case of making a false document and forgery, which are cognisable offences," the court said.

It further said that the alleged misrepresentation by

the first accused and the subsequent supply of fake journal publications and certificates prima facie satisfied the ingredients of cheating.

The court said police investigation was necessary as forensic examination of the alleged forged publication certificates, verification from the concerned universities and publishers, examination of electronic evidence including WhatsApp chats, call records and a laptop allegedly used to submit the applications, and tracing of the financial trail of the alleged Rs 1 lakh payment could not be effectively carried out by a private complainant.

The court also said investigation was required to ascertain whether other job-seeking candidates had similarly fallen victim to an alleged organised racket. The court clarified that registration of the FIR did not automatically warrant the arrest of any accused and directed the investigating agency to act strictly in accordance with law and the Supreme Court's guidelines on arrest.

Tata Power-DDL secures seventh power theft conviction this fiscal

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Court orders jail, Rs 3.79 lakh liability

NEW DELHI: Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (Tata Power-DDL) has secured seven convictions in electricity theft cases so far in the financial year 2026-27, with the latest conviction coming from the Patiala House Courts, as the utility continues to intensify its crackdown on power theft across North Delhi.

In the latest case, the Special Court sentenced the accused to one month of rigorous imprisonment, imposed a fine of Rs.10,000 and directed payment of civil liability amounting to Rs.3,79,124 under the Electricity Act, 2003.

The case originated from a complaint received by Tata Power-DDL's Corporate Enforcement Group, following which an inspection was conducted on February 17, 2023, at an unauthorised jhuggi opposite WZ-462, near the Pump House in Village Todapur, Dasghara.

During the inspection, the enforcement team found the accused, Devi Prasan, allegedly drawing electricity illegally by

directly tapping the low-tension (LT) network distribution box through unauthorised wires. Officials assessed a connected load of 7.408 kW, with the electricity being used for domestic purposes as well as operating a concrete mixer machine and charging e-rickshaws.

The inspection team documented the alleged theft through photographs and videography, removed the illegal wires and seized them as evidence. The theft assessment was calculated at Rs.3,79,124.

After examining the inspection report, seizure memo, site plan, photographs, video-graphic evidence and witness testimonies, the court of Addi-

tional Sessions Judge Syed Zishan Ali Warsi at Patiala House Courts held the accused guilty under Sections 135 and 150 of the Electricity Act, 2003. Besides the prison sentence and fine, the court also ordered payment of the assessed civil liability under Section 154(5) of the Act.

Tata Power-DDL, which supplies electricity to around nine million consumers in North Delhi, said the conviction reflects its continued efforts to curb electricity theft through regular enforcement drives and sustained legal action while reinforcing that power theft carries both criminal and financial consequences.

Ggm cops suspended after accused escapes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Two police officials were suspended and departmental inquiries initiated against a head constable and a SHO in Gurugram after an accused arrested in Madhya Pradesh escaped from their custody, officials said on Friday.

According to the police, in connection with a fraud case registered in Sector-14 police station in January this year, a police team had travelled to Madhya Pradesh in the complainant's private vehicle to apprehend the accused, Prakash Razzaq. After taking the accused into custody, the police were bringing him back to Gurugram for interrogation and further legal proceedings.

On Wednesday, while the vehicle was being refuelled at a petrol pump in the Garoth town of Madhya Pradesh's Mandasaur district the accused fled with the four-wheeler. He

abandoned it a short distance away and escaped into the forest. The accused's father was also present in the vehicle at the time, they added.

Taking cognizance of the matter, Gurugram Police senior officials initiated action against the responsible personnel after a preliminary inquiry revealed negligence in the line of duty and the use of the complainant's private vehicle by the police team, they said.

"Based on the inquiry report, two police personnel were suspended with immediate effect. Additionally, orders have been issued to initiate a departmental inquiry against the Moharrar head constable and the SHO of the Sector-14 police station. A detailed investigation into the matter is underway, and strict action in accordance with the rules will be taken against any officer or employee found guilty," said a senior police officer.



Delhi Police's North district organised a child welfare programme at the Salaam Baalak Trust's Children's Home for Boys in Tis Hazari as part of Child Safety Awareness Month

MPOST

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445 WATERLOGGING HOTSPOTS UNDER WATCH

The great drain gain: Over 90% desilted

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: With heavier monsoon spells expected over the coming weeks, the Delhi government has intensified flood-control preparations by accelerating drain desilting, expanding pumping infrastructure and deploying emergency response systems across the Capital. Officials say the objective is to minimise water-logging, ensure uninterrupted traffic movement and improve response time during intense rainfall.

The Public Works Department (PWD), the Capital's largest drain-owning agency, maintains 1,405 km of roads and a 2,123.78-km storm water drainage network—nearly half of Delhi's total drainage system. According to the department's report dated July 2, desilting has been completed along 1,955.08 km, or 92.06 per cent of the network.

Zone-wise, 539.34 km (95.60 per cent) has been desilted in the East Zone, 603.39 km (94.03 per cent) in the South Zone and 812.35 km (88.50 per cent) in the North Zone. Officials said

the remaining stretches are being cleaned and all extracted silt is being removed within 24 hours to prevent it from re-entering drains.

Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said, "Our priority is to clean the drainage network and make it functional to ensure that even during heavy rainfall, water does not accumulate and disrupt movement. For this, we have strengthened the manpower and the desilting work is ongoing at the desired pace with overall more than 90 per cent of the work completed."

He added, "Officials have also been directed to ensure proper disposal of the silt and prevent it from flowing back into the drains."

Long-term infrastructure strengthened

To improve the city's drainage capacity, PWD has floated 89 tenders worth Rs 2,270.89 crore for pre-cast drain works. Work is underway on 31 tenders, while the remaining 58 are under various stages of processing.

The department has also expanded permanent flood-



FILE PHOTO (IANS)

management infrastructure. The number of permanent pump houses has increased from 157 last year to 167 this year, while pumps have increased from 735 to 754. Of these, 212 pumps are automated and operational, while the remaining 542 continue to operate manually. Complete automation has been targeted by May 31, 2027.

For vulnerable locations, 313 high-capacity Power Take-Off (PTO) pumps have been deployed at 286 sites, compared to 277 pumps at 261 locations

during the previous monsoon season.

Hundreds of vulnerable locations under watch

The Delhi government has identified 169 highly vulnerable waterlogging locations across the city. In addition, officials have mapped 445 waterlogging hotspots based on Delhi Traffic Police records from 2023, 2024 and 2025. Of these, 31 are located along Ring Road alone and remain under continuous monitoring during

the monsoon. Nodal officers have been appointed for all 448 identified vulnerable locations under PWD's jurisdiction. A 24-hour control room at the department's headquarters, accessible through toll-free helpline 1908, coordinates with field engineers, district administrations and Delhi Traffic Police.

CCTV cameras have already been installed at several locations, while surveillance is being expanded to another 77 waterlogging-prone points to

enable real-time monitoring and quicker response.

To tackle localised flooding, 200 maintenance vans staffed by five-member teams have been deployed across Delhi. Rapid Action Teams remain on round-the-clock duty, while horticulture teams have been instructed to promptly clear fallen trees and branches obstructing traffic.

Permanent solutions at chronic flooding points

Officials said Minto Bridge, one of Delhi's most flood-prone stretches, has now been provided with a permanent solution through construction of an additional drain and automation of the pumping system.

At Zakhira Underpass, where flooding has been aggravated by encroachments and garbage dumping, nearly 90 per cent of drainage improvement work has been completed and the remaining work is expected to finish by July 15.

Pul Prahladpur has also received a permanent flood-management system comprising a SCADA-enabled automated pump house, a 7.5-lakh-litre underground sump and a 600

HP pumping arrangement. Other locations under close monitoring include Azadpur Underpass, Loni Gol Chakkar, NH-24 Patparganj, Dasmesh Road, ITO and Jahangirpuri.

Other civic agencies also scale up preparedness

The Irrigation and Flood Control (I&FC) Department, which maintains around 382 km of major drains including the Najafgarh, Barapullah and Delhi Gate drains, has completed nearly 93 per cent desilting across 77 drains. More than 31 lakh metric tonnes of silt has been removed, with over 30 lakh metric tonnes already disposed of through landfill sites, embankment formation and designated disposal locations.

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has also exceeded its Phase-I desilting targets. Officials said 1.7 lakh metric tonnes of silt was removed from 793 major storm-water drains, achieving 125.88 per cent of the target. For smaller drains, 29,686.83 metric tonnes of silt was cleared from 12,892 drains, surpassing the target by

achieving 114.84 per cent. The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) reported 100 per cent cleaning of all 7,888 bell-mouths and 4,833 gully traps under its jurisdiction. NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal said 337 of the council's 340 rainwater harvesting systems have also been serviced, achieving a completion rate of 99.12 per cent. Between January and June, NDMC removed around 885 cubic metres of silt from bell-mouths, gully traps and manholes.

Flood monitoring across Delhi

To strengthen flood preparedness, the government has established 16 flood-control posts, including nine along the Yamuna, four on the Najafgarh drain, two on the Supplementary Drain and one near the Jahangirpuri drain. Eight embankments have also been constructed along the Yamuna to strengthen flood protection. Officials said arrangements have additionally been made to seek Army assistance, if required, during severe flooding or emergency situations.

Will take action: Min on app shutting down E-rickshaws

NEW DELHI: Delhi Transport Minister Pankaj Singh on Friday said that the government will take appropriate action in the matter related to a mobile application being used to shut down E-rickshaws.

Following the circulation of several videos on social media, the Delhi government has ordered a probe into the claims.

"This is a matter of security, and to ensure that people do not face inconvenience or distress, the government will certainly take appropriate action. We also received this information through social media. The transport department was also investigating and checking the matter," Singh told PTI Videos. The Delhi Police was conducting an inquiry into it as well. As far as I have been informed, the Centre has taken action against it, he added.

In a major crackdown, the Central government has ordered removal of three Chinese apps — BAT-BMS, Lossigy, Epoch-i-ion — that were being misused to remotely disable battery-operated vehicles in the country, sources said on Friday. The action came after some videos surfaced showing that some e-rickshaws were being rendered inoperable through a remote shutdown feature linked to the Chinese smartphone application BAT-BMS.

PTI

SC order on CAG audit of discoms 'procedural': Min

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Power minister Ashish Sood called a Supreme Court order staying an order of his department for CAG audit of power discoms in the city as "procedural" in nature and not a "clean chit" to the power distribution companies.

The Delhi government had ordered a CAG audit of power discoms against the backdrop of a staggering Rs 38,500 crore accumulated over the years as Regulatory Assets (RA) that are to be recovered from consumers. The Court, while passing the order, said that the legality of the power regulator Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission's (DERC) decision to appoint the CAG gives rise to questions for a judicial determination.

"The interim order passed by the Supreme Court is a procedural order intended to preserve the status quo until the legal issues are examined in detail," Sood said in a statement.

It is neither a final verdict on the merits of the case nor a clean chit to the private power distribution companies, he stated.

The Court has fixed the matter for hearing on July 15, where



the legal framework governing the audit mechanism will be examined. The Delhi government has proceeded throughout this matter with complete honesty, transparency and in accordance with law, Sood said.

"We are fully prepared to place our case before the Supreme Court on 15 July and demonstrate why an independent and rigorous CAG audit is necessary to safeguard the interests of Delhi's electricity consumers and taxpayers," he said.

The power minister said that the Supreme Court has "recognised" that important legal questions concerning transparency and accountability in Delhi's power sector deserve detailed consideration. An interim stay is not a victory for the discoms. The Court has not held that the CAG audit is illegal and has simply preserved the existing position while examining the legal framework.

"Significantly, the Court has also directed that liquidation of the Regulatory Assets will remain stayed until further orders. We welcome this protection extended by the Hon'ble Supreme Court in public interest," Sood said. This is a "major relief" for the people of Delhi because it prevents immediate implementation of a mechanism that could have ultimately translated into a massive financial burden on electricity consumers, he said. The "resistance" to the audit raises serious questions, Sood said and added that the urgency with which discoms have attempted to prevent the CAG audit raises obvious questions. "If there is nothing to hide, there should be no objection to an independent public audit conducted under constitutional supervision," he said.

Delhi government is fighting to protect Delhi's consumers, said the minister and added it can not allow a potential burden of nearly Rs 38,500 crore to be transferred onto the people of Delhi through higher tariffs and surcharges without strict and independent financial scrutiny.

INAUGURATION



CM Rekha Gupta inaugurates the new front block and physiotherapy centre at Lajpat Nagar Colony Hospital PTI

GOVT ROLLS OUT 7-YEAR CLEAN AIR MISSION

Cleaner skies get ₹8,300 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Friday announced Rs 8,300 crore for a seven-year programme to combat air pollution in the national Capital.

The World Bank will provide 65 per cent of the funding, while the Delhi Government will bear the remaining 35 per cent.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the "Clean Air, Healthy Delhi" project will be implemented from September 2026 to August 2033 and will aim to strengthen air quality management and reduce emissions from major pollution sources across the city.

Gupta said a special workshop will be held on July 10 to finalise preparations for the programme and strengthen coordination among all stakeholders. The workshop will define the roles of various departments



and agencies and discuss the roadmap for the effective and timely implementation of the project, she said. According to the chief minister, the project will accelerate the implementation of Delhi's air pollution mitigation plan, support the objectives of the National Clean Air Programme and contribute to the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. The Environment Department's project will cover key sectors contributing to pollution, including transport, road dust, construction and demolition waste, solid waste management, industries, green spaces and water pollution.

Gupta said the initiative is not merely a pollution control programme but a long-term investment aimed at providing Delhi residents with cleaner air, better public health and a more sustainable urban environment.

She added the initiative rests on two major pillars, strengthening air quality management and reducing emissions from major pollution sources. Under the first component, the government will establish a dedicated Project Management Unit, develop advanced air quality monitoring systems, build data analytics capabilities and set up an Integrated Command and Control Centre-based monitoring system.

The project also envisages closer coordination with states in the Indo-Gangetic Plain, scientific planning, public awareness campaigns and adoption of new technologies. The second component focuses on reducing emissions by phasing out older polluting vehicles, promoting electric vehicles, strengthening public transport and developing an advanced Pollution Under Control monitoring system for vehicle emissions.

The chief minister said several departments and agencies, including the Environment Department, Delhi Pollution Control Committee, Transport Department, Public Works Department, Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Jal Board, Delhi Development Authority, New Delhi Municipal Council and Delhi Traffic Police, will jointly implement the programme. The Department of Economic Affairs and the World Bank will also be key partners in the initiative.

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दिल्ली सरकार

दिल्ली पर्यटन

दिल्ली पर्यटन द्वारा

नरेन्द्र मोदी

प्रधानमंत्री

रेखा गुप्ता

मुख्यमंत्री

35वां आम महोत्सव

2026

3 से 5 जुलाई 2026

दिल्ली हाट, जनकपुरी, नई दिल्ली

सुबह 12 बजे से रात 9 बजे तक

मुख्य आकर्षण

400+ किस्मों के आमों की भव्य प्रदर्शनी

पुरुषों और महिलाओं के लिए मजेदार आम खाने की प्रतियोगिता

ताजे आमों और मैंगो प्रोडक्ट्स की बिक्री - सीधे किसानों से

हर दिन रंगारंग सांस्कृतिक कार्यक्रम - सुबह से शाम तक

बच्चों के लिए खास किड्स ज़ोन - खेल, कला और इंटरैक्शन के साथ

मनमोहक सेल्फी पॉइंट

क्विज़ और स्लोगन लेखन प्रतियोगिता - 100 है दाम जितना भी खाओ आम और भी बहुत कुछ... स्वाद, संगीत और संस्कृति का संगम!

दिल्ली टूरिज़्म के साथ मिलकर मनाइए आमों का त्योहार - एक अनोखा अनुभव, पूरे परिवार के लिए!

पहुँचना है आसान!

तिलक नगर मेट्रो स्टेशन से दिल्ली हाट तक फ्री शटल सेवा उपलब्ध है!

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IRAN PREZ INVITED PM MODI IN FUNERAL

Union minister Margherita, Bihar Gov attend Khamenei’s funeral ceremony

NEW DELHI: Union minister of state Pabitra Margherita and Bihar Governor Syed Ata Hasnain attended the funeral ceremony of Iran’s late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei on Friday and paid their respects on behalf of the government and the people of India.

Khamenei, who ruled Iran for last three decades, was killed on February 28, the first day of massive US and Israeli air strikes on Tehran.

“Hon’ble @GovernorBihar and I represented India at the funeral ceremony for Grand Ayatollah Seyyed Ali Khamenei, former Supreme Leader of Iran, in Tehran. Conveyed our respects on behalf of the Government and the people of India. @PMOIndia @MEAIndia,” Minister of State for External Affairs Margherita posted on X and also shared some photos the ceremony.

The Bihar Lok Bhawan in a post on X said the governor also extended deepest condolences to the families of those who have lost their lives in the recent conflict in West Asia.

“Represented India at the funeral ceremony of His Eminence Grand Ayatollah Seyyed Ali Khamenei in Tehran today, along with MoS External



Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita and Bihar Governor Syed Ata Hasnain as part of an official Indian delegation attend the funeral ceremony of Iran’s slain supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei

Affairs @PmargheritaBJP. Also extended deepest condolences to the families of those who lost their lives in the recent conflict. @MEAIndia @atahasnain53,” the governor’s office posted.

It also shared some photos of the solemn ceremony.

The Embassy of Iran in India also issued a post sharing visuals of Hasnain and Margherita offering their respects in a hall where the ceremony to mourn his death was held.

“The Special Representatives of the Government of the Republic of India, Bihar Governor Lieutenant General (Retd.) Syed Ata Hasnain and Mr. Pabitra Margherita, Minister of State for External Affairs, paid tribute to the martyred Leader of the Islamic Republic of Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei,” and also shared a video carrying the visuals.

In a separate post, the Iranian embassy said, “A delegation of Indian religious leaders

paid tribute to the martyred Leader of the Islamic Republic of Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei,” and also shared a video carrying the visuals.

Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian had invited Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the funeral.

Former external affairs minister Salman Khurshid is representing the Congress party at the funeral ceremony. External Affairs Ministry

Highlights

» Khamenei, who ruled Iran for last three decades, was killed on February 28, the first day of massive US and Israeli air strikes on Tehran

» Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian had invited Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the funeral

spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal at his weekly media briefing was asked who represented India at the ceremony as many persons are attending it.

“The high-level representation in the ceremony underscores the importance of civilizational ties, including people-to-people connection, between the two countries, providing a robust foundation to political and economic engagements,” the MEA said in its July 2 statement.

The main funeral procession in the Iranian capital is scheduled for July 6, according to Iran’s state-run media.

On July 7, ceremonies will be held in the holy city of Qom, and the burial in Khamenei’s hometown of Mashhad is scheduled for July 9.

AGENCIES

Monsoon advances across north India

Continued from Page 1

And other departments to stay alert and work closely with state governments to provide timely advice to farmers on suitable kharif crops. The meeting also discussed ensuring uninterrupted electricity supply for farmers, monitoring water levels in reservoirs across the country and promoting crops that require less water, including millets, pulses and fodder crops. Shah directed the Department of Water Resources to closely watch reservoir levels, while the Power Secretary was asked to ensure adequate electricity supply. He also said sufficient stocks of essential food grains, including rice and wheat, were available and prices of essential commodities remained stable.

The review comes as India recorded a rainfall deficit of about 40 per cent in June, with Central India reporting the highest shortfall of 50.4 per cent. The India Meteorological Department has projected below-normal rainfall for July as well. Low rainfall has affected agriculture, with kharif sowing declining 23 per cent to 182.72 lakh hectares as of June 25.

On the ground, Himachal Pradesh reported three rain-related deaths during the 24 hours ending 4 pm Thursday. Two people died of electrocution in Kangra and Shimla districts, while another person died after slipping from a height in Mandi district.

Heavy rain also disrupted normal life in the hill state. The State Emergency Operations Centre said 49 roads were blocked, while three power transformers and 23 water supply schemes were affected. The Hindustan-Tibet Road, or National Highway-5, which was blocked near Choling in Kinnaur district after a debris flow triggered by heavy rain, was reopened after clearance operations.

In Chamba district, around 24 pilgrims stranded near a temple in Bharmour since Wednesday were rescued after flash floods washed away a temporary wooden bridge. Authorities have also advised tourists visiting Sach Pass to avoid prolonged stays because sudden snowfall could create difficulties.

Rajasthan witnessed widespread rainfall as the monsoon advanced across more parts of the state. Several districts in eastern Rajasthan experienced thunderstorms, gusty winds and light to moderate rain, while isolated places recorded heavy showers. Western Rajasthan also received light to moderate rainfall accompanied by strong winds.

Heavy rain caused waterlogging in urban areas and villages in Chittorgarh, Bhilwara and Rajsamand districts. In Jaipur, rainwater entered the trauma centre of Sawai Man Singh Hospital, affecting the emergency ward, ECG room and X-ray section, causing inconvenience to patients

and staff. Overnight rain also blocked several roads in Kapsasan and Nimbaheha tehsils of Chittorgarh district. The weather department has forecast more heavy rainfall across eastern and southeastern Rajasthan in the coming days.

In Uttar Pradesh, rainfall remained uneven. The state received 9 per cent above-normal rainfall on Friday, but its cumulative rainfall deficit since June 1 stood at 43 per cent. West Uttar Pradesh recorded 6.4 mm rainfall, 34 per cent above normal, while East Uttar Pradesh received 6 mm, 4 per cent below normal. Budau recorded the highest rainfall at 38 mm, followed by Chitrakoot with 30 mm and Kanpur City with 27.3 mm. However, several eastern districts, including Bahraich, Ballia, Basti, Deoria and Mirzapur, recorded no rainfall.

Delhi, where the monsoon arrived a day earlier, remained cloudy and humid. The Safdarjung weather station recorded 0.8 mm rainfall, while the city’s maximum temperature settled at 35.8 degrees Celsius. Despite lower temperatures, the “feels-like” temperature reached 46.2 degrees Celsius because of high humidity.

In Jammu and Kashmir, the twin Amarnath Yatra base camps at Baltal and Nunwan received rain during the morning, while higher reaches experienced intermittent showers. Punjab and Haryana, however, largely remained dry through the day.

From Page 1

Centre clears

aerial systems and drone swarms.

The MPATGM system will enhance the Army’s capability to engage enemy tanks and armoured vehicles at short and medium ranges. The missile system is intended to provide greater mobility to infantry units operating in mountainous, desert and urban terrain while reducing dependence on imported anti-tank weapons.

The MRSAM weapon system provides air defence against fighter aircraft, helicopters, drones, cruise missiles and precision-guided munitions. Jointly developed by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and Israel Aerospace Industries (IAI), the Barak-8-based system formed a key part of India’s air defence network during Operation Sindoor, intercepting aerial threats as part of a layered defence architecture.

The Army will also induct the V-SHORADS, which provides portable air defence against low-flying aircraft, helicopters and drones, particularly in frontline, high-altitude and border areas. The council further approved procurement of the Active Protection System for tanks, which detects and intercepts incoming anti-tank guided missiles, rocket-propelled grenades and loitering munitions before they strike, improving the survivability of armoured formations against modern anti-armour threats.

The approved jet-based kamikaze drone system will provide the Army with a high-speed precision strike capability against high-value targets, including air defence systems, radar stations, command centres, ammunition depots and logistics hubs. Owing to its higher speed, the system is expected to be more difficult to intercept than conventional propeller-driven loitering munitions.

For the Indian Navy, the DAC approved procurement of the Multi Influence Ground Mine (MIGM), Naval Shipborne Unmanned Aerial System (NSUAS) and the establishment of a Land Based Testing Facility (LBTF) for electric propulsion systems.

The MIGM is an advanced seabed mine that detects enemy warships and submarines through a combination of magnetic, acoustic and pressure signatures before engaging them. The system is intended to strengthen sea denial capabilities while protecting ports, naval bases and key maritime routes in the Indian Ocean Region.

The NSUAS is designed to operate from naval warships, extending surveillance beyond a ship’s radar horizon and providing real-time intelligence. It will also support anti-piracy, anti-smug-

gling and maritime security operations. The proposed Land Based Testing Facility will enable shore-based testing of electric propulsion systems and other critical technologies before they are integrated into operational warships.

For the Indian Air Force, the council approved procurement of the Fixed-Wing High Altitude Pseudo Satellite (FW-HAPS) and other proposals. The FW-HAPS platform is intended to provide persistent intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance capabilities, besides supporting telecommunications and remote sensing missions over extended durations.

According to defence experts, the approved acquisitions address emerging battlefield challenges by strengthening India’s multi-layered defence architecture, improving force protection and precision strike capability, and supporting the armed forces’ transition towards technology-driven and network-centric warfare. The approvals also align with the government’s continued focus on expanding indigenous defence manufacturing and reducing dependence on imported military equipment.

Meta

are in a constant battle with criminals who hide among our 3.5 billion users and try to evade our detection,” the spokesperson said.

“Our expert teams are constantly working to improve our defences, develop new technology to root out predators, block links to violating websites, and share intelligence with other companies so they can take action too,” the spokesperson added.

Under India’s Information Technology Act, publishing or transmitting electronic material depicting children in sexually explicit acts is punishable by law. Section 67B specifically criminalises creating, publishing, transmitting, downloading, storing or distributing online child sexual abuse material.

The Information Technology Rules also require intermediaries, including social media platforms, to follow due diligence obligations. Failure to comply can result in the loss of safe harbour protection that shields platforms from liability for third-party content.

The government has maintained a zero-tolerance approach towards CSAM, requiring online platforms to detect, remove and report such content promptly while strengthening safeguards for children. It has also blocked websites carrying CSAM based on lists received from Interpol through the Central Bureau of Investigation, India’s national nodal agency for the international police organisation.

Officials have repeatedly cautioned technology companies that failure to act against CSAM and other harmful online content could lead to regulatory action.

The latest development comes days after the Centre issued

another notice to Meta over WhatsApp’s proposed username feature. The government raised concerns that the feature could increase phishing attempts, online fraud, impersonation and so-called digital arrest scams, and directed the company to pause the rollout until consultations are completed to the government’s satisfaction.

Sources said WhatsApp has agreed to defer the launch of the feature. A Meta delegation has already met IT Ministry officials, and the company is expected to submit a detailed reply within the three-day timeline set by the government. The Centre has also asked Meta to explain why action should not be initiated under the IT Act and relevant rules, reminding WhatsApp of its due diligence obligations as a significant social media intermediary.

SIT

The SIT has already questioned Trust general secretary Champat Rai, trustee Anil Mishra and Gopal Rao, who has been associated with the temple’s construction and management. Rai and Mishra have submitted their resignations from their respective posts. The Trust is expected to consider the resignations at its meeting scheduled for July 6.

According to police, investigators have recovered Rs 20.39 lakh from Shukla, Rs 18.07 lakh from Karunesh Pandey, Rs 16.82 lakh from Anukalp Mishra, Rs 14.25 lakh from Lavkush Mishra, Rs 7.32 lakh from Ramashankar Mishra and Rs 1 lakh from Ramashankar Yadav, also known as Tinnu.

The investigation has also led to the recovery of around 11 grams of gold, about 375 grams of silver and USD 1,121. Police also seized a donation box marked “Ramrajya Kosh” carrying a Paytm QR code from a yoga centre in Ayodhya where Shukla had allegedly been staying for nearly a decade.

The probe has also brought Varanasi-based Sainik Security Services under scrutiny. The agency had supplied 22 employees for deployment at the Ram Temple complex, where they were assigned duties related to temple security, treasury operations and counting cash donations.

Officials said all 22 employees were residents of Ayodhya and were recruited by the agency before being deployed at the temple following a recommendation from officials of the State Bank of India branch in Ayodhya.

Investigators have questioned the agency’s management, supervisor and several employees. The SIT is examining whether proper background verification was carried out before the personnel were entrusted with responsibilities involving devotees’ donations.

Agency director Gaurav Singh said the firm had only supplied manpower at the bank’s request. “Our agency is 26 years old. The bank had asked us to provide

employees. They were hired on the recommendation of the bank and deployed accordingly,” Singh said.

He said the agency had no role in the donation-counting system. “We were asked by the bank to provide staff. We supplied 22 employees to the temple trust. They were engaged for house-keeping and allied duties and were deployed after the bank sought manpower from us,” he said.

The alleged embezzlement came to light on June 7. An FIR was registered on June 25 based on the SIT’s preliminary report after the Uttar Pradesh government constituted the investigation team.

Eight people associated with the temple’s donation-counting process have been arrested so far. The SIT is now trying to determine whether weaknesses in recruitment, supervision and financial oversight enabled the alleged diversion of donations from one of the country’s most revered temples.

Meanwhile, Bageshwar Dham chief Acharya Dharendra Krishna Shastri said he had faith in the investigation and the legal process.

“God will punish the culprits. We have complete faith in the country’s law and order system and in the SIT,” he told reporters. “Whoever has committed this sin will be punished by God, and the SIT, the law of the country and the government will also punish them,” he added.

Chinese apps

BAT-BMS is a Bluetooth-enabled battery management application developed by China’s Shenzhen Grenergy Technology Co. Ltd. It is designed to monitor and manage compatible lithium battery packs by displaying information such as charge level, voltage, current and temperature, while also allowing users to control charging and discharge functions.

Officials said concerns stem from the absence of password protection or strong authentication in some Bluetooth-enabled battery management systems used in low-cost e-rickshaws. This allegedly allowed anyone within a Bluetooth range of around 15 metres to pair with compatible batteries, switch off the discharge output and leave vehicles stranded. The app can also connect to multiple batteries at the same time.

Lossigy and Epoch-i-ion are similar battery management applications used with Bluetooth-enabled lithium batteries from other manufacturers.

Some reports claimed pranksters displayed e-rickshaws using the apps and later demanded money to restore them.

Earlier in the day, IT Secretary S Krishnan said app stores must exercise due diligence and that the government would engage with them to ensure potentially harmful applications are not made

available. The move comes as India increases scrutiny of digital platforms and connected technologies over cybersecurity, data security and the resilience of critical digital infrastructure.

MEA

New Delhi has also argued that the treaty has become inequitable over time as it grants Pakistan extensive rights over the western rivers despite changing geopolitical realities and India’s growing water needs.

Pakistan has termed India’s move “illegal” and equivalent to an act of war. It has stepped up diplomatic efforts at the United Nations, initiated proceedings before the Permanent Court of Arbitration and accused India of “weaponising” water.

Separately, the MEA condemned Pakistan’s recent military strikes inside Afghanistan that reportedly caused civilian casualties. Jaiswal reaffirmed India’s support for Afghanistan’s sovereignty and territorial integrity, adding that humanitarian assistance and development projects in the country continue.

On the death of Indian seafarer Rakesh Chauhan in Venezuela, the MEA said the Indian Embassy in Caracas has sought a thorough investigation into allegations that his mortal remains were desecrated and some organs removed. The ministry said it is closely monitoring the case and remains in contact with Venezuelan authorities.

Bombay HC

directed Chaudhary to remain externed for one year.

According to the petition, Chaudhary was externed after he and party workers organised protests, marches and demonstrations against certain decisions of the Union government. Several FIRs were registered against him for staging protests and raising slogans against the Government of India, the BJP and Union Home Minister Amit Shah. Police argued that the protests had been conducted without the required permission.

Justice Jamdar, however, found that merely organising protests against government decisions could not justify an externment order under the Maharashtra Police Act.

Dictating the order in court, the judge said, “The petitioner acting in his capacity has arranged Morchas and Dharnas against certain decisions taken by the Government of India. That cannot be a ground for a person to be externed under the Maharashtra Police Act. The action taken is mala fide action.”

The court further observed that the action infringed Chaudhary’s constitutional rights.

“As per Articles 19 and 21 of the Constitution of India not

only citizens have the freedom to express their opinion but also to live with dignity. The action taken by the respondents against the petitioner for merely opposing certain decisions of the Government of India affects his fundamental rights,” the judge said. During the hearing, Justice Jamdar questioned the basis for the police action, asking, “Why externment orders for slogans? Can’t citizens raise such slogans? Why can’t citizens protest against government actions and decisions?”

The judge also noted that there was nothing on record to indicate that the protests had caused any harm. In the absence of such material, the demonstrations alone could not form the basis for an externment order.

Justice Jamdar also made light-hearted observations on recent political developments in Maharashtra. Referring to legislators switching parties, he remarked, “Even you should switch sides. Anyways horse trading is going on in entire Maharashtra. You have some FIRs against you. Consider switching sides. There is a washing machine.”

The judge also commented that while a child had recently died in an accident, political attention was focused on party defections and the election of a presiding officer in the state assembly, before proceeding to allow the petition and quash the externment order.

UIDAI

(3.1 crore) downloads within five months of its launch.

To date, over 4 million people have updated their mobile numbers using the new Aadhaar app. At the same time, about one million people have used the app for updating their address.

Anti-doping law

substances, administering banned substances to athletes, supplying such substances to minors, organised criminal activities linked to doping, sale of prohibited substances without prescribed labelling, and advertisements or paid promotions encouraging doping.

Officials said punishments will be determined under the provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), depending on the nature of the offence. Trafficking and distribution of prohibited substances to athletes could attract imprisonment of up to five years.

A Sports Ministry official said the focus has shifted from penalising athletes alone to acting against those enabling doping. “Until now, athletes were penalised for such infractions. They would get suspensions or bans. But we need to go after those who supply them with these sub-

stances, including medical practitioners,” the official said.

The amendments revive provisions that were proposed in 2018 but later dropped before the legislation was passed in 2022 and subsequently amended. At that time, the government had eventually opted for what it described as preventive legislation instead of criminal legislation.

The proposed changes come as India’s doping record continues to attract global attention. The latest AIU sanctions list places India at the top with 162 athletes and support personnel serving sanctions, ahead of Kenya with 148 and Russia with 60. The list includes not only positive tests but also violations such as tampering with samples, evading testing, trafficking and whereabouts failures. India has also remained among the top two countries in athletics ADRVs over the last four years.

According to AIU data, the country recorded 48 ADRVs in 2022, 63 in 2023, 71 in 2024 and 30 so far in 2025, amounting to 212 violations between 2022 and 2025. India has also topped the World Anti-Doping Agency’s global list for the past three years.

Earlier this year, World Athletics designated India as an “extremely high-risk” country for doping. Following that assessment, the AIU Board upgraded the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) from Category B to Category A under Rule 15 of the World Athletics Anti-Doping Rules, placing Indian athletics under stricter monitoring and testing requirements.

“Unfortunately, the quality of the domestic anti-doping programme is simply not proportionate to the doping risk,” AIU Chair David Howman had said while announcing the decision.

International agencies have also raised concerns. International Testing Agency Director General Benjamin Cohen earlier said, “We’re concerned in general with the state of doping in India and we’re hearing a lot of things happening on the ground.”

The scale of the challenge was visible earlier this year when several sprinters reportedly left a New Delhi athletics meet after anti-doping officials arrived to conduct in-competition testing.

Officials said the amendments are intended to strengthen India’s anti-doping framework, improve institutional independence, provide greater procedural clarity and ensure faster adjudication of doping cases while aligning domestic law with India’s commitments under the UNESCO Convention against Doping in Sport.

The legislative push also comes as India expands its international sporting ambitions. The country has secured hosting rights for the 2030 Commonwealth Games, is pursuing a Diamond League meeting and continues to push its bid to host a future Olympic Games, making a stronger anti-doping framework a key priority for protecting the credibility of Indian sport.

MEA says 75 years of India-Japan ties to be celebrated in 2027

Modi to launch several projects in Rajasthan and Gujarat today

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Healing with dignity: CM Sai impressed by Sothi Ashram's work

Attempt to bribe TVK MLA: Five more held

Electoral democracy faces gravest threat from Modi-Shah regime: Cong

भारतीय विमानपत्तन प्राधिकरण
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नागर विमानन मंत्रालय
भारत सरकार

श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी
माननीय प्रधानमंत्री

जोधपुर हवाई अड्डे का विस्तार राजस्थान में खोले संभावनाओं के नए द्वार

जोधपुर हवाई अड्डा

JODHPUR AIRPORT

जोधपुर हवाई अड्डे के नए टर्मिनल भवन

का उद्घाटन

श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी
माननीय प्रधानमंत्री
द्वारा किया जाएगा

शनिवार 04 जुलाई, 2026 | 10:45 बजे | जोधपुर हवाई अड्डा, जोधपुर

परियोजना के लाभ

- चार गुना अधिक क्षेत्रफल (23,342 वर्गमीटर) वाले अत्याधुनिक टर्मिनल भवन से सुविधाजनक हवाई यात्रा
- जोधपुर एवं आस-पास के क्षेत्रों के पर्यटन उद्योग को बढ़ावा
- क्षेत्र में आर्थिक विकास और रोज़गार के नए अवसरों का सृजन
- स्थानीय उत्पादों के निर्यात एवं व्यापार की संभावनाओं में वृद्धि

परियोजना की प्रमुख विशेषताएं

- ₹ 480 करोड़ की लागत से मारवाड़ की शाही वास्तुकला से प्रेरित सरस्टेनेबल विशेषताओं वाला आधुनिक टर्मिनल भवन
- व्यस्ततम समय में प्रति घंटे यात्री सेवा क्षमता 200 से बढ़कर 1500; वार्षिक यात्री सेवा क्षमता 20 लाख
- 20 चेक-इन काउंटर, 03 कन्वेयर बेल्ट, 06 एक्स-रे बैगेज स्कैनर एवं 06 पैसेंजर बोर्डिंग ब्रिज
- विमान पार्किंग क्षमता 04 से बढ़कर 12 (ए-320 प्रकार के विमान)

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

श्री हरिभाऊ किसनराव बागड़े
राज्यपाल, राजस्थान

श्री गजेंद्र सिंह शेखावत
केन्द्रीय संस्कृति, एवं पर्यटन मंत्री

श्री भजन लाल शर्मा
मुख्यमंत्री, राजस्थान

श्री मुटलीधर मोहोल
केन्द्रीय नागर विमानन, एवं सहकारिता राज्य मंत्री

श्री किंजरापु राममोहन नाथइ
केन्द्रीय नागर विमानन मंत्री

श्री राजेन्द्र गहलोत
संसद सदस्य, राज्य सभा

@AAI_Official @AirportsAuthorityOfIndiaOfficial @aaiofficial @AirportsAuthorityofIndia @airportsauthorityofindia डीडी न्यूज़ पर लाइव प्रसारण देखें

CBC 03111/13/0004/2627

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'DIFFERENCES OVER MEETING MINUTES RESOLVED'

Stage set for next phase of Ladakh dialogue

MPOST BUREAU

LEH: Leaders of the Leh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) on Friday said they had resolved differences over the minutes of an earlier meeting with the Ministry of Home Affairs, calling it a positive step towards formal negotiations on a proposed democratic framework for the Union Territory of Ladakh.

The breakthrough came less than a fortnight after Ladakh's civil society groups held a shutdown on June 23 over the alleged omission of key understandings from the May 22 Minutes of Meeting (MoM) and unilateral decisions by the Lt Governor-led administration on issues such as land, liquor, power, transport and tourism.

The LAB and KDA, which are jointly spearheading an agitation seeking statehood for

INSIGHT

» The breakthrough came less than a fortnight after Ladakh's civil society groups held a shutdown on June 23

» The LAB and KDA have held several rounds of talks with the Centre since 2021

» The LAB co-chairman said they had urged the Centre to expedite the next round of negotiations



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

Ladakh and the extension of constitutional safeguards under the Sixth Schedule to the region, have held several rounds of talks with the Centre since 2021.

The differences over the MoM were resolved at an informal meeting in Leh on Friday attended by MHA officials, representatives of the LAB and KDA including Ladakh MP Mohammad Haneefa Jan and senior UT administration offi-

cials, with all sides signing the revised minutes after reaching a consensus.

"There was an extensive discussion on the sticking points we had, particularly regarding the Minutes of the Meeting. After detailed deliberations, a consensus was finally reached on those issues. In the end, all of us signed the copy of the Minutes," LAB co-chairman Chering Dorjay Lakrook told

reporters.

Describing the meeting as constructive, he said the government had made a genuine effort to accommodate Ladakhi sentiments.

Dorjay said discussions on constitutional safeguards also moved forward. According to him, the MHA indicated that instead of simply replicating existing provisions under Articles 371A to 371J, Ladakh could

receive a framework offering even stronger protection.

"As for Article 371, the discussion took place broadly along the same lines as before. One additional point they mentioned was that they believe there could be an option even better than the existing provisions under Articles 371A to 371J. That has also been recorded in the Minutes," he said. He said concerns relating to the Annual Performance Reports (APRs) of officials had largely been resolved.

The LAB co-chairman said they had urged the Centre to expedite the next round of formal negotiations.

"We urged the government to hold the official talks at the earliest so that we can reach a conclusion as soon as possible," he said. On the proposed draft for Ladakh's future governance structure, Dorjay said

the MHA's draft was still under preparation, while the Apex Body had already completed its own proposal.

"The MHA has informed us that its draft is not yet complete and is still under preparation. The draft prepared by the Apex Body is complete and is with us. However, I received it only a short while ago, so I have not yet had the opportunity to study it. We will discuss it with the KDA before they leave for Kargil," he said.

Dorjay said the MHA officials had conveyed that Union Home Minister Amit Shah wanted the long-pending Ladakh dialogue to reach an early conclusion. "The government is very positive; the Home Minister wants this matter—which has become quite protracted—to be brought to a logical conclusion as quickly as possible," he said.

MONSOON WATCH

HM Shah reviews El Niño preparedness



NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah and Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Thursday reviewed the likely impact of the southwest monsoon, including the possibility of below-normal rainfall in parts of the country due to the El Niño weather phenomenon.

During the meeting, Shah said the Centre was closely monitoring the progress of the monsoon and its potential impact, particularly the risk of drought-like conditions in some regions.

He directed the Ministry of Agriculture and other concerned ministries to remain on alert and work in close coordination with state governments to advise farmers on crop planning in line with the prevailing weather conditions.

The Home Minister also asked the Ministry of Jal Shakti to closely monitor water levels in reservoirs across the country, including groundwater reserves, and promote the cultivation of drought-resistant crops such as millets and pulses, along with fodder crops for livestock in areas likely to be affected.

He further directed the Ministry of Power to ensure that there is no disruption in electricity supply during the monsoon season.

Officials informed the meeting that the country's

Mumbai records over 70 mm rain in 5 hours

MUMBAI: Incessant rains continued to pound Mumbai on Friday, with several areas recording over 70 mm of downpour in just five hours as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) forecast "heavy to very heavy" showers over the next 24 hours.

According to civic officials, the highest rainfall of 73.8 mm was recorded at Supari Tank Municipal School in Bandra, followed by 72.2 mm in Prabhadevi, 70.8 mm in Bandra West and 69.4 mm in Parel.

The IMD has forecast heavy to very heavy rainfall in the city and its suburbs over the next 24 hours, accompanied by gusty winds reaching 50-60 kmph.

MPOST

foodgrain stocks, including rice and wheat, were adequate and that prices of essential commodities remained stable.

The review meeting was attended by the ministers in charge of Cooperation, Agriculture, Water Resources, Consumer Affairs, Animal Husbandry, Environment, Power, Rural Development, and Science & Technology.

'Vision 2050': J'khand govt to host 2-day stakeholders meet in Delhi

RANCHI: The Jharkhand government will hold a two-day national stakeholders' consultation in New Delhi from July 8 to advance its ambitious Vision 2050 roadmap and attract investment across key sectors, an official statement said on Friday.

The event, to be led by Chief Minister Hemant Soren and organised by the departments of Information Technology, Industries and Tourism, will bring together policymakers, industry leaders, investors, technology experts and development partners from India and abroad to discuss the state's long-term development strategy.

The consultation aims to position Jharkhand as a preferred destination for investments in information technology, artificial intel-



ligence, digital governance, industry and tourism, while creating employment opportunities and promoting innovation.

During the event, the government will release draft policy frameworks for stakeholder feedback. These include policies on artificial intelligence, investment promotion, tourism, textiles, Jharkhand Industrial Area Development Authority (JIADA) regulations, public-private partnerships and the proposed Jharkhand Founda-

tion, among others.

The first day will focus on digital governance and IT infrastructure, followed by Business-to-Government (B2G) meetings between government officials and representatives of the IT, AI and digital technology sectors.

The second day will highlight investment opportunities, inclusive development and tourism, showcasing Jharkhand's industrial strengths and cultural heritage before domestic and international investors. **MPOST**

Himachal CM steps up bid to take control of 3 hydel projects

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: After having ensured the state's share in the Rs 15,000-crore Kishau Multipurpose Dam Project on the Tons River (a Yamuna tributary), Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu has intensified efforts to reclaim the state's rights over three major hydro-power projects currently allotted to SJVN Ltd.

Chairing a high-level meeting of the Power Department on Thursday, Sukhu directed officials to begin the process of taking over the 382 MW Sunni, 210 MW Luhri Stage-I and 66 MW Dhaulasidh hydroelectric projects. He said the state government was committed to protecting the interests of the people of Himachal Pradesh and ensuring that the state's

Sukhu directed officials to begin the process of taking over the Sunni, Luhri Stage-I and Dhaulasidh projects

natural resources were utilised for public welfare. The CM said the government would continue to pursue the state's rightful share in its hydropower resources through all appropriate forums. He asked officials to take necessary steps to maximise benefits from projects located within the state.

Sukhu also directed the department to renegotiate the terms and conditions of the 500 MW Duggar hydroelectric project being developed by

NHPC after the company proposed increasing the height of the dam. He said any revision in the project's design must be matched by enhanced benefits for Himachal Pradesh.

Referring to the recently resolved impasse over the 422 MW Kishau Multipurpose Dam Project, Sukhu said the state government had broken an eight-year deadlock and secured a favourable agreement. Under the revised arrangement, Himachal Pradesh will not have to make any capital investment while receiving 211 MW of free power from the project.

The Kishau project, a joint venture involving Himachal, Uttarakhand, Haryana, Rajasthan and Delhi, is expected to generate nearly Rs 600 crore in annual revenue for the state.

EFFORTS TO ENHANCE FARMERS' INCOME

'Hry govt to focus on sustainable agriculture'

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: With the objective of making Haryana a leading agricultural state in the country and enhancing farmers' income, Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Friday reviewed the agriculture department's five-year roadmap and action plan in a meeting here.

In the meeting, the focus was on increasing farmers' earnings by integrating agriculture with modern technologies, reducing cultivation costs, and ensuring better market access.

Reviewing the progress of state government and budget announcements related to the Agriculture Department, the chief minister directed officers to implement the "Vision-2047" goals within the stipulated timeframe so that every farmer benefits from government schemes and agriculture becomes more profitable.



FILE PIC

Saini said the objective of Haryana Vision-2047 is not merely to increase agricultural production but also to enhance farmers' incomes and make agriculture future-ready.

A review was also done regarding the campaign to reclaim waterlogged, saline agricultural land.

Officers apprised the chief minister that a target has been set to reclaim 1.40 lakh acres

Saini said the objective of Haryana Vision-2047 is not merely to increase agri production but also to enhance farmers' incomes

of such land during the current year, an official statement said. The chief minister directed that a scientific plan to prevent the recurrence of the problem in the future and that a system for regular satellite-based monitoring be developed.

Reviewing the Soil Health Card scheme, officers informed that the state has set a target of issuing 15 lakh cards.

In the first phase, 3.75 lakh soil samples are to be collected, of which 50,620 samples have

already been gathered. The remaining target is expected to be completed by July.

Saini directed that school and college students and rural youth be engaged as volunteers in the campaign so that they gain an understanding of soil testing while also developing a greater interest in agriculture.

He further suggested that in districts with high urea consumption, soil test reports should be analysed to determine whether there is an actual nitrogen deficiency or whether farmers are applying urea in excess of the required quantity. Based on the findings, an appropriate strategy should be prepared to promote balanced fertiliser use among farmers.

During the meeting, detailed discussions were also held on promoting natural and organic farming.

Haryana CM reviews Rakhigarhi museum project

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini has directed officials to develop the proposed Site Museum and Interpretation Centre at Rakhigarhi to international standards so that it emerges as a global showcase of India's ancient civilisation, cultural heritage and knowledge traditions.

Chairing a high-level review meeting in Chandigarh on Thursday evening, Saini said Rakhigarhi should become more than an archaeological site and evolve into a world-class heritage destination that presents the legacy of the Saraswati-Sindhu Civilisation through modern and immersive technologies. Senior officials, including Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi and Heritage and Tourism Department Commissioner and Secretary Amit Agrawal, attended the meeting.

Officials informed the Chief Minister that the museum complex, spread over nearly 100,000 sq ft, will feature 10 theme-based galleries equipped with advanced digital, electronic and audio-visual technologies. Visitors will be able to explore various aspects of the ancient civilisation, including its urban planning, residential architecture, drainage systems, water management, trade, livelihoods, social life and technological achievements.

The Orientation Gallery will provide insights into the Civilisation of the Seven Rivers and the evolution of the Saraswati-Sindhu Civilisation through short films, digital projections and 3D presentations. The centre will also include experiential learning zones where children and young visitors can participate in interactive activities such as seal-making, studying replicas of artefacts and traditional games. Officials said archaeological excavations are underway at three of Rakhigarhi's seven mounds, and the museum will document excavation process and major discoveries that enhanced understanding of ancient civilisation. **MPOST**

'First-of-its-kind' auction: ED sells Hawker jet for Rs 3 crore

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI/HYDERABAD: Enforcement Directorate (ED)'s Hyderabad Zonal Office, in a first-of-its-kind auction of property acquired under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, sold a Hawker 800A Aircraft for Rs 3 crore through MSTC Limited.

The proceeds from the sale will be distributed among investors allegedly duped in a multi-crore fraud, as directed by the Special PMLA Court.

The aircraft was auctioned on July 1 after being attached by the ED during a search conducted at the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport in Hyderabad on March 7, 2025. The attachment was made in connection with a money laundering investigation against Amardeep Kumar, his com-



pany Capital Protection Force Pvt. Ltd., and others.

The Adjudicating Authority under the PMLA confirmed the attachment on August 18, 2025, and subsequently permitted the sale of the aircraft on November 20, 2025, in accordance with the provisions of the PMLA Rules.

The money laundering case stems from three FIRs registered by the Economic Offences Wing, Cyberabad, alleging that Amardeep Kumar and his Falcon Group cheated

investors of nearly Rs 792 crore through a fictitious invoice discounting scheme. According to the ED, the company lured investors by promising returns from invoice discounting transactions that, in reality, did not exist.

During the investigation, the ED arrested Sandeep Kumar, brother of the prime accused, chartered accountant Sharad Chandra Toshniwal and Aryan Singh Chhabra, CEO of Falcon Invoice Discounting. The agency filed its prosecution complaint before the designated court on September 29, 2025.

The ED said the auction marks the first disposal of a property attached under the PMLA, with the sale proceeds earmarked for restitution to the defrauded investors in accordance with court directions.

Sandipani Vidyalayas to mirror Guru Sandipani Ashram's ethos and promote social equity

MP: 70 Sandipani Vidyalayas ready for inauguration; Guru Purnima events planned across all dists

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh will develop its newly built Sandipani Vidyalayas on the ideals of Guru Sandipani Ashram, with an emphasis on inclusive education, social equity and value-based learning, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav said on Friday.

Reviewing the progress of the state's Sandipani Vidyalayas at the Secretariat, Chief Minister Yadav directed officials to ensure that the institutions embody the principles associated with Guru Sandipani, who, he said, imparted education without discrimination based on caste, class, wealth or social status. He said the schools should become centres of quality education rooted in Indian values while fostering equality and social harmony.

The CM instructed the School Education and Tribal Affairs departments to make the inauguration of the newly constructed schools a community celebration rather than a routine official event. The programmes, to be held under the ongoing 'School Chalein Abhi-



yan', should involve students, parents, public representatives and local residents through cultural performances, competitions and other educational activities. To familiarise students with Guru Sandipani's philosophy, Yadav directed officials to publish a pocket book on the sage's life and teachings for distribution in the schools. He said the initiative would help students understand India's ancient knowledge tradition, the guru-shishya tradition and the importance of moral values.

Yadav said the schools should be inaugurated in the presence of district in-charge ministers and local public representatives. He also directed

that Guru Purnima celebrations on July 29 be organised at one Sandipani Vidyalaya in every district, featuring science exhibitions, teacher felicitation, presentations on student and teacher innovations, demonstrations of digital and artificial intelligence (AI) applications, and recognition of meritorious students.

Secretary, School Education Department Sanjay Goyal informed the Chief Minister that construction of 70 Sandipani Vidyalaya buildings has been completed, including 46 under the School Education Department and 24 under the Tribal Affairs Department, and all are ready for inauguration.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Pocket book on Guru Sandipani for students
- » Community-led inauguration events planned
- » Focus on Indian values and moral education
- » Cultural events to boost enrolment

CHHATTISGARH

SECI denies fixing rooftop solar surplus power rate

NEW DELHI: The Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI) has clarified that it has neither fixed nor finalised the purchase rate for surplus electricity generated by rooftop solar consumers in Chhattisgarh, terming reports suggesting otherwise as factually incorrect.

In a communication issued to the publication, SECI referred to an article published on June 29, 2026, titled "Chhattisgarh: 'Solar users to see surplus credit in upcoming bills'", which stated that SECI had fixed the purchase rate for surplus power exported to the grid by rooftop solar consumers. SECI said the statement was incorrect and could inadvertently create a misunderstanding regarding its role in the process.

"SECI has neither fixed nor finalised any purchase rate for surplus energy for rooftop solar consumers in the state of Chhattisgarh," it said. **MPOST**

Nation Briefs

L-G SAXENA INAUGURATES RESTORED POND IN LEH'S MATHO VILLAGE

LEH: Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Friday inaugurated the rejuvenated Matho village pond in Leh under Project Him Sarovar,



a flagship initiative to strengthen water security and sustainable agriculture in Ladakh. The revived pond is the third water body completed under the project since its launch in April. The restoration, carried out by the Irrigation and Flood Control Department, followed Saxena's directions after his visit to the village. The project is inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of water conservation.

HONEYMOON MURDER: SC REFUSES TO STAY HC ORDER GRANTING BAIL TO SONAM

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday refused to stay a Meghalaya High Court order granting bail to Sonam Raghuvanshi, accused of killing her husband during their honeymoon in the northeastern state in 2025. A bench of Justices M M Sundresh and Sheel Nagu expressed reservation over the high court order but refused to stay it, noting that Raghuvanshi has been released from jail and is in Shillong pursuant to the bail conditions imposed by the trial court.



EDITORIAL

IGNORING
WARNING SIGNS

The first spell of the monsoon has barely arrived, yet the Himalayan states are once again counting the dead. Six lives were lost in Himachal Pradesh after heavy rains triggered landslides and flash floods in the higher reaches of the state. Roads disappeared under debris, vehicles were swept away and villages found themselves cut off within hours. For many Indians, such tragedies have become seasonal headlines that briefly command attention before fading into the background. For the people who live in the mountains, however, they are painful reminders that each monsoon now arrives with a sense of dread rather than relief. The question that must be asked is painfully familiar: after years of catastrophic floods, landslides and infrastructure collapse, why do these disasters continue to unfold with such alarming predictability? The answer cannot simply be that rainfall has become more intense because of climate change. Nature may trigger these disasters, but human choices increasingly determine their scale. The Himalayas have become a testing ground where ecological fragility is repeatedly sacrificed at the altar of rapid development, often with devastating consequences.

The last four years should have fundamentally changed the way India approaches development in its mountain states. Himachal Pradesh witnessed unprecedented destruction during the 2023 monsoon, with thousands of landslides, hundreds of deaths and damage running into tens of thousands of crores. Uttarakhand has lived through the Kedarnath disaster, the Chamoli glacier collapse, repeated cloudbursts and recurring floods. Scientific institutions have repeatedly warned that the Himalayas are among the world's youngest and most unstable mountain systems, making them exceptionally vulnerable to geological disturbances. Yet road-widening projects continue to cut through unstable slopes with inadequate slope stabilisation, tunnels are excavated with limited cumulative environmental assessments, riverbeds are mined for construction material, and forests that once anchored fragile hillsides continue to shrink. Ironically, many of the locations witnessing repeated landslides are precisely those where highways have recently been widened or large infrastructure projects have transformed the landscape in the name of connectivity and economic growth. Better roads undoubtedly improve access, tourism, trade and defence logistics. But when engineering ignores geology, every kilometre of new infrastructure can become a future disaster site. Development that repeatedly destroys itself cannot be described as development; it merely shifts today's gains into tomorrow's losses.

Equally disturbing is the growing perception among residents that governments have become trapped in a cycle of repair rather than prevention. Across Himachal Pradesh, many citizens argue that public works departments spend most of their time rebuilding roads damaged in previous monsoons instead of investing in long-term resilience. The same criticism echoes through Uttarakhand. Every year, emergency funds are allocated to restore washed-away highways, repair bridges, stabilise slopes and compensate affected families. Yet relatively little attention appears to be directed towards strengthening drainage systems, enforcing scientific land-use planning, relocating settlements from high-risk zones or restoring degraded forests that naturally reduce erosion. Disaster management often remains reactive instead of anticipatory. Early warning systems have improved, weather forecasting has become more sophisticated and satellite monitoring has advanced considerably. However, technology alone cannot compensate for planning failures. A warning is useful only if roads have been engineered to withstand extreme rainfall, slopes have been reinforced before the monsoon begins, and vulnerable communities have realistic evacuation plans. When infrastructure repeatedly collapses in the same locations, the issue is no longer merely one of extreme weather but of institutional learning—or the lack of it.

Climate change undoubtedly compounds these challenges. Rising temperatures are altering rainfall patterns across the Himalayas, producing shorter but far more intense bursts of precipitation. Glacial retreat is changing river behaviour, while warming slopes increase the likelihood of rockfalls and landslides. But invoking climate change cannot become an excuse for overlooking poor governance or weak environmental oversight. In fact, a changing climate demands even greater caution in development planning. Every new highway, hydropower project, tourism complex or hillside settlement should undergo cumulative risk assessments that consider the combined impact of multiple interventions across an entire river basin rather than evaluating projects in isolation. Environmental impact assessments must regain scientific credibility instead of becoming procedural formalities. Independent geological audits should guide infrastructure alignment, while bioengineering techniques, slope vegetation and natural drainage restoration should become integral to construction rather than optional add-ons. Equally important is regulating tourism in ecologically sensitive zones, where unplanned hotels, parking facilities and commercial construction place additional pressure on already unstable landscapes. The economic value of tourism itself depends on preserving the mountains that attract visitors in the first place.

India cannot afford to view the annual devastation in the Himalayas as an unavoidable cost of progress. Economic growth that repeatedly claims lives, destroys homes and consumes billions of rupees in reconstruction is neither efficient nor sustainable. The people of Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand and other Himalayan states deserve infrastructure that protects rather than endangers them. They deserve roads that survive the monsoon instead of collapsing with every heavy shower. They deserve governments that measure success not by the kilometres of highways inaugurated but by the resilience of the communities those highways serve. As another monsoon gathers strength, the tragedy unfolding in the mountains should not simply prompt another round of emergency relief. It should compel a fundamental rethink of how India builds in one of the planet's most fragile ecosystems. The Himalayas have sustained civilisation for centuries. They cannot be expected to bear unlimited ecological and engineering burdens without consequence. The true measure of development lies not in conquering the mountains, but in learning to live within the limits they impose.

BHARAT
KI SOCH



ANIL RAJPUT

THE WRITER IS
CHAIRPERSON,
BHARAT KI SOCH

Abhimanyu teaches us one of the greatest life lessons — courage does not mean the absence of fear, but the willingness to act despite uncertainty

Abhimanyu Beyond the Battlefield

Abhimanyu's story moves beyond sacrifice to examine how courage, ethics, mentorship and leadership together shape the fate of individuals and nations

There are moments when destiny does not wait for age, experience or perfect preparation. It arrives suddenly, demanding courage before comfort and duty before hesitation. In the Mahabharat, Abhimanyu stands at such a moment. Young in years, but radiant in valour, he enters the Chakravayuh knowing that he possesses only partial knowledge of its design. Yet he does not step back, because the responsibility before him is greater than his fear. His story is remembered for bravery, but its deeper meaning lies in the questions it leaves behind: What does courage require? What happens when knowledge is incomplete? What do elders, leaders and institutions owe to the young who step forward in trust?

Abhimanyu was the son of Arjun and Subhadra, and the nephew of Shri Krishna. Raised in the Pandav tradition, he inherited courage, discipline and a sense of duty. Yet his place in the Mahabharat does not come only from lineage. His conduct gives him a distinct identity as a young warrior of confidence, purity of intention and deep commitment to dharma.

The most defining episode of his life comes during the Kurukshetra war, when the Kaurav army forms the Chakravayuh, a complex military formation. Arjun, the warrior most capable of breaking it, had been drawn away from the battlefield. His absence exposed a deeper weakness: organisations can fail when they depend only on a hero leader and do not build wider competence within the system. According to popular tradition, Abhimanyu had learnt how to enter the Chakravayuh while still in his mother's womb, but he did not know how to come out of it. When the moment arrives, he honestly states this limitation. Yet he agrees to enter, trusting that the senior Pandav warriors will follow him. This is where his story becomes more than battlefield heroism. It becomes a lesson in courage with duty, trust in leadership and the cost of incomplete preparation.



His legacy is not merely the memory of a young warrior who fell in battle

Abhimanyu's decision teaches one of the first great life lessons of his story: courage does not mean the absence of fear, but the willingness to act despite uncertainty. He does not enter the Chakravayuh because the task is easy or because success is guaranteed. He enters because the situation requires someone to act. In life too, responsibilities often come before we feel fully ready. Abhimanyu reminds us that maturity is not always measured by age, but by the seriousness with which one accepts responsibility.

Yet his story also teaches that courage alone is not enough. Never confuse courage with readiness. Abhimanyu had the talent to break into the formation, but not the full knowledge to come out. His tragedy lies not in a lack of bravery, but in the incompleteness of preparation and support around him. Talent may be born, but preparedness is built. Young people are often praised for energy, confidence and sacrifice, but praise is not preparation. Great leaders build competence before they demand commitment. Talent must be nurtured before it is tested, and enthusiasm must be guided before it is exposed to danger.

The ethical dimension of Abhimanyu's story is equally powerful. Once inside the Chakravayuh, he fights with

extraordinary skill, but when the senior Pandav warriors are prevented from following him, he is left alone against many seasoned warriors. The manner in which he is surrounded and attacked becomes one of the Mahabharat's most painful examples of dharma collapsing in war. The epic reminds us that even conflict has rules, and even victory must remain within the boundaries of fairness. Victory without fairness weakens the moral legitimacy of those who win it. The Kaurav side may have gained a battlefield advantage, but the way Abhimanyu was killed exposed the decay of their moral order. Success achieved through unfair means may produce immediate gain, but it damages trust, respect and conscience. Rules are safeguards of dignity. When rules are bent only to defeat someone, institutions lose their moral centre. One may win some battles in the short run, but ultimately lose the larger war of trust, honour and dharma.

His story also carries deep moral lessons about sacrifice and dignity. Abhimanyu does not abandon his duty even when he is isolated. He continues to fight, not out of hatred, but out of commitment. His courage is not noisy arrogance. It is disciplined resolve. This teaches the value of commitment without complaint and dignity under pressure. True

character is revealed not when circumstances are favourable, but when support disappears and the path becomes lonely.

At the same time, Abhimanyu's sacrifice should not be romanticised without reflection. It is not enough to say that he was brave and move on. His story asks whether such sacrifice could have been prevented, whether elders had fulfilled their duty of preparation, and whether systems that praise the young after loss do enough to protect them before crisis. Society must not glorify sacrifice in order to hide failure of responsibility. Honour for the brave must be accompanied by accountability from those who guide them.

For leadership, Abhimanyu offers lessons that are both inspiring and cautionary. He shows the strength of youthful leadership: quick decision-making, self-belief, fearlessness and devotion to a larger cause. But his story also reveals a collective failure. Those around him trusted his courage, but the system did not fully protect him when the plan broke down. There was overconfidence in talent, dependence on the assumption that others would cope, and a failure of the support system when he was blocked from help. Great organisations rarely fail because their brightest people lack courage. They fail when leadership mistakes cour-

age for preparedness. A leader's duty is not only to inspire people to step forward, but to ensure that they have the knowledge, resources and backing needed to succeed.

This applies strongly to modern India. A nation filled with young talent must not merely celebrate ambition. It must build systems that guide, train and protect that ambition. Young minds need mentorship, young professionals need direction, and young citizens need opportunity. Abhimanyu represents the fire of youth, but his story reminds us that fire must be protected from being consumed too early.

Abhimanyu also teaches that incomplete knowledge can be dangerous when combined with pressure. In a fast-moving world, people often act on fragments of knowledge, half-understood strategies or incomplete advice. His story reminds us of humility before complexity. Asking for guidance is not weakness. Preparing fully is not hesitation. True courage becomes stronger when it is joined with learning.

His life, though brief, leaves behind a moral force that continues to speak across generations. His greatness lies in one decisive moment where character, courage and duty came together. Abhimanyu teaches the young to be brave and disciplined. He teaches elders to be responsible and protective. He teaches leaders that strategy without ethics can become cruel, and admiration without support can become empty.

In the end, Abhimanyu's story is not only about entering the Chakravayuh. It is about the courage to step into difficulty, the dignity to stand firm when abandoned, and the duty of others to ensure that courage is not left alone. He reminds us that life demands bravery, but bravery must be guided by wisdom. Sacrifice can inspire generations, but it must also awaken responsibility. His legacy is therefore not merely the memory of a young warrior who fell in battle. It is the enduring lesson that courage deserves guidance, talent deserves protection and dharma must never be sacrificed for victory.

Views expressed are personal

AT
VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL

THE WRITER
IS AN AUTHOR
AND MEDIA
ENTREPRENEUR

Over 1.7 million die in India due to air pollution annually. Every year, we lose human lives and are thwarted in our economic efforts because of lack of clean air

Clean Air = Economic Growth

The Delhi government's proactive plans to fight toxic winter air is as welcome as its EV policy. Can it be a green mobility model for other states?

Is India finally taking its air pollution problem seriously? For the first time ever, a state government has proactively announced air pollution-fighting tactics way before the onset of the punishing cold. For far too long, Indian states, particularly in the north, have grappled with noxious air right after Diwali. Vehicular pollution, construction dust, and stubble burning in neighbouring states turn our national capital into a gas chamber every year. Though we won't know with certainty till the time is nigh, there is reason to be cautiously optimistic. The winter of 2026 could look, feel, and smell different. Almost half a year before the deadly onslaught of toxic air, the Delhi government has already announced permanent anti-pollution curbs to contain air pollution.

Every year between November and February of the following year, Delhi rules global headlines as the most polluted city in the world. AQI (air quality index) touches never-before-seen heights, debates follow over methodologies, the people suffer, business gets hampered, and life expectancy steadily reduces for its citizens. Instead of waiting for winter to announce measures retrospectively, the Delhi government has already put in place a slew of decisions that may just tip the scales in its favour. The moves come into effect on November 1, 2026 and stay in place till February 28, 2027, irrespective of AQI. These restrictions will be in effect alongside GARP (Graded Response Action Plan) that is implemented depending on AQI in the peak pollution months.

During this period, parking charges will double to disincentivise the use of private cars. Staggered office hours and an encouragement of work-from-home, including in government offices, is a major relief to citizens as well. Government and private offices have been directed to work with no more than



The Delhi state government must be appreciated for at least attempting to move with the times

50 per cent of staff strength between November 1 and January 31. Essential, medical, and emergency services will be exempted from the directive. Non-Delhi registered vehicles below BS-VI won't be permitted to enter city limits. Dust-spawning activities such as demolition and civil construction, except public infrastructure projects, will remain banned between November 1 and January 31. A complete prohibition on construction, except for urgent government or emergency works, will be in place between December 10 and January 20. Large commercial buildings and construction sites have been mandatorily asked to use anti-smog guns and mist systems to lessen pollution. The government has also roped in the community, exhorting residential welfare associations (RWAs) to ensure that there is no open burning of waste, biomass, plastic, etc.

A new world demands a restructured system, and the Delhi state government must be appreciated for at least attempting to move with the times. Announcing the steps early also gives businesses and operators precious time to get their house in order. In the state's

long-term vision are plans to remove petrol autorickshaws and scooters and transition to electric vehicles in total. Delhi EV Policy 2026 is screaming the intentions out loud — zero road tax on cars priced up to Rs 30 lakhs (ex-showroom), new ICE (Internal Combustion Engine) vehicle registrations scrapped for autorickshaws by 2027 and two-wheelers by 2028, and a cash incentive of over USD 1,000 for those willing to change over to EV. These are indeed handsome stimuli to switch to green mobility; these could also be some of the most attractive EV impetus currently prevalent in the world. By comparison, the southern Indian state of Karnataka ended its lifetime road tax exemption for EVs in April this year, and brought on a new levy system, to recoup lost state revenues.

An effective implementation of the Delhi EV policy would entail an infrastructural overhaul that provides superior charging capabilities, enhanced atmanirbhar or Indian-made battery supply chains, and less dependence or susceptibility to global shocks. If triumphant, the Delhi government may not

just turn the tide on annual air pollution but also provide a model for sustainable mobility for the rest of the country. The road is tough, as it often is. But with Delhi as one of India's fastest-growing EV markets, the ambitious plans may see fruition if backed with strong administrative will and people's consent. It's an odyssey worth undertaking because on the other side lies a USD 220-billion economic opportunity waiting to be unlocked.

Hazardous air is a public health crisis; to a citizen, it's an impingement on their right to live. Over 1.7 million die in India due to air pollution annually. Every year, we lose human lives and are thwarted in our economic efforts because of lack of clean air. A recent analysis presented by international strategy consulting firm, Dalberg, at IVCA Clean Air Forum 2026, extols the benefits of clean air on India's GDP (gross domestic product). The prospective value creation caused by clean air can be to the tune of 5.5 per cent of last year's GDP! Just shrinking PM2.5 pollution levels by 20 per cent could free up a staggering USD 220 billion of economic opportunity by 2030. Safe, breathable air can mean greater productivity, less absenteeism, and better health outcomes with less medical expenditure on account of poor health. The analysis highlights that lowering pollution would support 1.4 million jobs while decreasing 115 million tonnes of CO2 every year. An investable opportunity to create clean air solutions remains in sectors such as transport, agriculture, residential combustion, solid waste management, industrial emissions control, construction and road dust management, power generation, and air quality monitoring. We now need private capital that can propel innovation and leverage government intent to make this happen. Maybe, we should start in Delhi first.

Views expressed are personal

RELIGIOUS LEADERS AND FOREIGN DIGNITARIES WALKED UP TO KHAMENEI'S CASKET

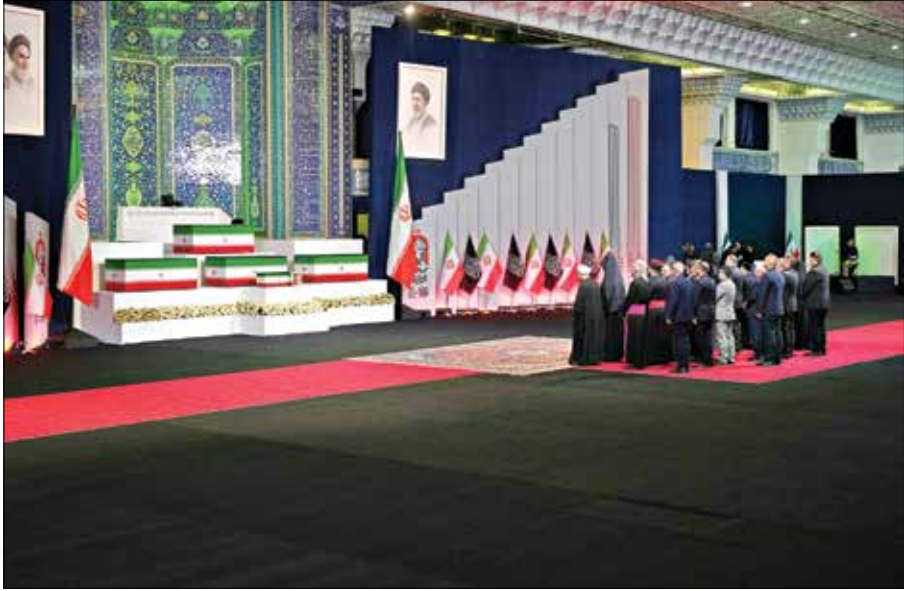
Iran prepares for dayslong funeral for its late Ayatollah

TEHRAN: Iran prepared Friday for the dayslong funeral of the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, with banners across Tehran urging the public to rise up in support of the Islamic Republic after the devastating war that killed the 86-year-old cleric.

The country's theocracy plans to see millions flood the streets of the capital beginning Saturday in scenes reminiscent to the burial of the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini in 1989.

That could provide a boost for Iran's government, particularly as it tries to leverage its hold on the Strait of Hormuz in negotiations with the United States over a permanent end to the war, and as concern still lingers that Israel could attack yet again.

Despite that, a powerful general who leads Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard emerged publicly for the first time in months for the funeral. Other top government officials will also likely be on hand alongside foreign dignitaries in



Foreign religious leaders and other mourners pay their respects before the coffins of slain Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and members of his family during a viewing ceremony in Tehran on Friday

a show of strength of Iran. "As long as these people, who are chosen (by God), are on the field, we will definitely continue the same 'no to humiliation' policy that was

founded by the Islamic Republic," said Mohammad Hossein Rezaei, a volunteer preparing for the funeral Friday. "We will continue our policy of pursuing independence,

and decisions will be made inside the country, and the people will decide their own fate," he said.

Khamenei's flag-draped coffin sat at Tehran's Grand Mosalla



A man rides a bicycle past a portrait of slain Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, in Tehran on Friday

Highlights

- » Khamenei's flag-draped coffin sat at Tehran's Grand Mosalla alongside family members
- » Top general appears for first time in months

alongside family members killed in the Israeli airstrike that came in the first moments of the war on February 28.

The dead being honoured include a son-in-law, his eldest daughter, a 14-month-old

granddaughter and the wife of Iran's new Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, the son of the previous leader who remains in hiding after reportedly being wounded in the attack.

Religious leaders and foreign dignitaries walked up to Khamenei's casket as a military band played or a man sang prayers. Iran's Parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and President Masoud Pezeshkian, key leaders in the country's civilian government, all paid their respects.

Video published by Iranian state media showed an earlier mourning ceremony Thursday night for Khamenei. The black-clad mourners, whom state media identified as coming from families of those who lost loved ones in the 12-day war in 2025 and the recent Iran war, threw scarves and other items for attendants to brush against the coffin, a common practice in Iran seen as a blessing.

Later, state media showed images of Khamenei's casket draped by a red flag with white calligraphy reading "Ya Hussein," a Shiite expression in remembrance of the 7th-century martyrdom of the Prophet Muhammad's grandson.

It had been flying over the Imam Hussein golden-domed shrine in Karbala, Iraq.

The flag also traditionally symbolises both the spilled blood of someone unjustly killed and a call for vengeance.

Photos published online by Iranian state media showed Gen Ahmad Vahidi attending a meeting Thursday about the funeral of Khamenei, then sitting alongside his casket as Iran's theocracy held a smaller service for him Thursday night near the supreme leader's former home in downtown Tehran.

"They must know that the pure blood of our martyred imam will mark another turning point in the victories of beloved Islam across the global arena," Vahidi told state television in comments aired Friday.

"They will take to their graves the wish to see this nation surrender. This nation will rise higher day by day through this pure blood."

Europe has backfilled most gaps from US cutbacks on military equipment

BRUSSELS: NATO's top commander told The Associated Press on Friday that European allies have filled most of the holes created by a US decision to cut back military contributions in times of crisis.

US Gen Alex Grynke-wich urged Europeans to make more equipment available after the US signalled on June 3 that it would no longer supply an aircraft carrier and support ships, aerial refuelling planes and dozens of fighter jets, among other assets, to the continent.

He also began weighing back up plans in case of an

attack against Europe. The so-called NATO Force Model is the alliance's Plan A for making forces from the 32 member nations available in times of peace, crisis or war.

It sets out the military assets that commanders can call on in phases over the first six months of any conflict.

"In a matter of weeks, European Allies have largely filled the gaps left by US reductions to the NATO Force Model," Grynke-wich said, days before President Donald Trump and his counterparts gather for a

July 7-8 summit in Turkey, where force planning will be high on the agenda.

"And in those few areas where they haven't, where they do not currently have a like capability to replace, we are looking at alternate capabilities with matching effect," Grynke-wich said. He provided no details.

In a decision that took many allies by surprise, the Pentagon informed its NATO allies that it would no longer provide as much as it focuses on potential threats elsewhere, notably from China in the Indo-Pacific region.

Rescue mission launches to save NASA telescope

NASA insisted on a rush job because the telescope will be too low to recover by the fall

CAPE CANAVERAL: A three-armed spacecraft rocketed into orbit Friday to rescue a NASA telescope that's in danger of crashing back to Earth.

Northrop Grumman launched Katalyst Space Technologies' Link spacecraft from the Marshall Islands in the Pacific. The Pegasus rocket blasted off from the belly of a modified aeroplane, putting Link on course to reach and capture NASA's Swift Observatory in about a month.

Launched in 2004, Swift is sinking faster than ever because of recent solar storms.

Takeaways

- » The Pegasus rocket blasted off from the belly of a modified aeroplane
- » It puts Link on course to reach and capture NASA's Swift Observatory in about a month

NASA'S HUBBLE SPACE TELESCOPE COULD BE A CANDIDATE FOR A SIMILAR SALVAGE OPERATION

NASA is paying \$30 million for Katalyst to capture the telescope and boost its orbit so it can continue tracking some of the biggest explosions in the universe, like gamma ray bursts and exploding stars.

If all goes well, Swift could be back scanning the cosmos by September. Observations are currently on hold to preserve the telescope's orbit as long as possible.

NASA's Hubble Space

Telescope could be a candidate for a similar salvage operation in a few years. It's also slipping in altitude because of increased atmospheric drag caused by the sun's outbursts.

The 1.6-ton (1.4-metric ton) Swift is currently circling 224 miles (360 kilometres) above Earth. Katalyst aims to raise the telescope's altitude by 150 miles (240 kilometres), back to where it all began. Link's thrusters will fire to boost Swift slowly, so there's no heavy jostling.

Katalyst threw the mission together in just nine months.

NASA insisted on a rush job because the telescope will be too low to recover by the fall. Without a boost, it's predicted to plunge to its demise in October.

Bad weather and technical issues caused a series of last-minute launch delays.

"This is a high-risk, high-reward mission," Katalyst Space CEO Ghonhee Lee said ahead of liftoff. "The biggest danger was always that we don't launch anything, and we let Swift burn up in the atmosphere. So we were always trying to avoid that risk, and our team has done that."

झारखण्ड सरकार
महिला, बाल विकास एवं सामाजिक सुरक्षा विभाग (समाज कल्याण निदेशालय)
द्वितीय तल्ला, ईजीनियर्स हॉस्टल, सेक्टर-III, धुर्वा,
रॉंची-834 004, दूरभाष संख्या-0651-2400749

पत्र संख्या- 1451/साकठ, रॉंची, दिनांक : 03.07.2026 ई0।
सूचना

समाज कल्याण निदेशालय, झारखण्ड, रॉंची अन्तर्गत e-Tender for printing and publication of "Jharkhand Badi" monthly magazine से संबंधित निविदा jharkhandtenders.gov.in के माध्यम से प्रकाशित की गई है, जिसका e-Tender Reference no.: PRO-01/2026 Date : 19.06.2026 एवं Tender ID: 2026_WCDSS_115382_1 है।
उक्त निविदा में corrigendum upload किए गए हैं जिसे Jharkhand Tenders के website https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in के माध्यम से देखा जा सकता है। हठ/—
PR 383975 (Women, Child Development & Social Security)26-27" सहायक निदेशक, समाज कल्याण

ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट सेल, पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता विभाग
झारखण्ड, रॉंची

ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट अल्पकालीन निविदा (SBD)
Tender reference No-DWSD/Cluster/GIRIDIH-1/SBD/20/2026-27
Dt. 03-07-2026

Sl No	Name of work	Cluster No.	Block	Estimate Cost (in Lakh)	Earnest money (in lakh)	Cost of BOQ (in Rs.)	Date of Completion
1	Implementation of Remaining Work under Cluster No. 25 for Single Village Water Supply Scheme under JJM in Block Jamua under DW&S Div. No.-1, Giridih for the year 2026-27	25	Jamua	370.33698	3.70337	10000.00	06 Months
2	वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि			06-07-2026	at 03:00 P.M.		
3	निविदा प्राप्ति (ऑनलाईन बिडिंग) की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय			20-07-2026	at 03:00 P.M.		
4	सरकार के सचिव, सूचना प्रौद्योगिकी एवं ई-गवर्नेंस, झारखण्ड मंत्रालय के जापोक 120 दिनांक 03.10.2023 के आलोक में विपत्र का मूल्य एवं अग्रचन की राशि। ऑनलाईन जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय			20-07-2026	at 03:00 P.M.		
5	बिड खोलने की तिथि/समय			21-07-2026	3:00 P.M.		
6	निविदा प्रकाशित करने वाले कार्यालय का नाम एवं पता		कार्यालयक अभियंता, पेयजल एवं स्व0 प्रमंडल संख्या-1, गिरिडीह।				
7	प्रोक्वोरमेंट पदाधिकारी का सम्पर्क संख्या			9304367422			
8	ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाइन संख्या			0651-250731			

➤ किसी भी प्रकार का बदलाव http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
➤ अन्य किसी भी प्रकार की सूचना http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
➤ निविदा में प्राक्कलित राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है। तत्पश्चात अग्रचन की राशि मान्य होगी।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता प्र0 सं0-1
गिरिडीह।

PR.NO.383924 Drinking Water and Sanitation(26-27):D

Public Works Department
Sector-19, North Block, Naya Raipur (C.G.)
E-Procurement Tender Notice
E-mail : tenders-pwd.cg@gov.in

NIT No. 611/TC/EinC/ PWD/2026-27 Dated 30.06.2026

The Engineer-in-Chief, Public Works Department on behalf of Governor of Chhattisgarh invites percentage rate bids on electronic tendering system under RCPLWE RRP-II in the district of Sukma for construction & maintenance of Road with estimated cost amounting Rs 217.79 Laes including their maintenance for five years from the contractors registered with unified registration system (e-registration) in Chhattisgarh. Non registered bidders may submit bid; however the successful bidder must get registered in appropriate class under "Unified Registration System (e-Registration) of Chhattisgarh before signing the agreement.

The bid document shall be available to bidders online free of cost and should be submitted online e-procurement system of government of Chhattisgarh in https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in. Bids form will be available on the website from 02.07.2026 and may be submitted up to 17:00 Hrs. on 23.07.2026

For participating in bidding process, bidders are required to register in the above web-site with nominal fee of Rs 500/- to be paid online to service provider. For submission of the bids, the bidder is required to have a valid Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) from authorized certifying authorities.

The bidders are required to submit (a) original bid security in approved form and (b) original affidavit duly verified and notarized as per clause 4.4 B (a) (ii) and 4.4 B (c) to Chief Engineer, Tender Cell, First Floor, Nirman Bhawan, PWD, North Block, Sector-19, Naya Raipur Atal Nagar (C.G.) 492-002 as per provisions of bid document through Speed/ Registered post, failing which the bids shall be declared non-responsive.

Detailed schedule of important dates may be seen on notice board of offices and also available on website of Public Works Department http://pwd.cg.nic.in

Chief Engineer
(Central Tender Cell)
Office of Engineer-In-Chief
P.W.D. Naya Raipur Atal Nagar (C.G.)

G 262701871/4

Pak: 40 killed after bus falls into ravine in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

PESHAWAR/ISLAMABAD: At least 40 people, including women and children, were killed when a bus they were travelling in fell into a ravine in northwest Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa on Friday, officials said. The Peshawar-bound bus departed from Quetta in Balochistan. The accident took place after it reached Dera Ismail Khan district in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, officials said.

Preliminary investigation suggests that the brakes of the bus failed, causing the driver to lose control while navigating a difficult bend on the mountainous terrain. The bus skid off the road and fell into the ravine. However, an investigation has been initiated to further examine the cause, officials said. "According to initial reports, 40 people have been killed and eight others injured in the accident," said Shahid Rind, who is Balochistan Chief



Soldiers and volunteers take part in a rescue work at accident site, in Dana Sar on Friday

Minister Sarfraz Bugti's aide for media and political affairs.

"District administrations from both provinces, rescue and other relevant departments are providing assistance to the affected persons," he said.

According to the 1122 res-

cue team, there were 48 people on board when the incident happened. The Dawn newspaper reported that 36 people were in the bus when it departed from Quetta, and the others boarded it on the way.

Deputy Commissioner of Sherani district Wali Khan Kakar said identification of the deceased and those who are injured is underway. Road accidents are common and often fatal in the mountainous regions of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa because of a combination of factors like treacherous terrain, extreme weather, frequent traffic violations, poor road conditions, poor vehicle conditions and untrained drivers.

President Asif Ali Zardari has directed relevant authorities "to ensure the provision of all possible and best medical facilities to the injured", his office said in a statement.

Putin shrugs off fuel shortages in Russia

MOSCOW: Despite severe fuel shortages across Russia, President Vladimir Putin appears unbothered by Ukraine's increasing attacks on his country's oil refineries.

He has shrugged off the setback for one of the world's leading oil-producing nations as "not critical", dismissed ceasefire proposals and insisted the war will continue until his goals are met.

Putin has described the attacks on Russian energy as an effort by Ukraine to distract attention from its losses on the battlefield, although analysts say the advance of Russian forces has been stymied in recent months. The Russian leader appears to believe his government can keep the fuel crisis from eroding his authority and support for the war he launched more than four years ago. The Russian military unleashed a massive 11-hour barrage on the Ukrainian cap-



Russian President Vladimir Putin

There have been more than 50 reported Ukrainian attacks on oil refineries

ital overnight into Thursday morning that killed at least 30 people. It was one of the deadliest attacks on Kyiv since the start of Russia's full-scale invasion.

There have been more than 50 reported Ukrainian attacks on oil refineries and other energy facilities in Russia and occupied Crimea.

TRUMP HEADS TO MOUNT RUSHMORE

Extreme heat bears down as America 250 celebrations ramp up

WASHINGTON: Festivities commemorating the 250th anniversary of American independence from Great Britain kick into higher gear across the United States on Friday as celebrations are balanced with efforts to stay safe as much of the country bakes under extreme heat.

President Donald Trump will travel to South Dakota to deliver a speech and watch fireworks at Mount Rushmore.

And in a novel twist, there will be a ball drop in New York City's Times Square at midnight to usher in the July Fourth holiday with much the same revelry that is typically reserved for New Year's Eve.

The activity culminates in the main event Saturday, when fireworks will erupt in communities across the US, along with backyard cookouts and block parties. Trump will deliver another speech at the



US President Donald Trump speaks at Burning Hills Amphitheatre during the Theodore Roosevelt Presidential Library opening ceremony

National Mall in Washington before what is being billed as a historically massive fireworks show.

But for all the celebrations, there are also serious safety considerations as potentially record heat grips much of the Midwest and East Coast.

Officials have warned those

celebrating the holiday to stay hydrated and take air-conditioned breaks as needed.

The heat has already affected some of the programming surrounding the holiday.

In Washington, organisers of the Capitol Fourth concert banned the public from attending a Thursday rehearsal because of the heat.

“FROM BOSTON TO NORRISTOWN, PENNSYLVANIA AND GETTYSBURG NATIONAL MILITARY PARK, PLANS WERE SHIFTING TO ACCOMMODATE THE SOARING TEMPERATURES”

The concert Friday, a staple of Washington's Independence Day traditions, is on, but the gates will open to the public later than usual, at 7 pm EDT, an hour before the show. Organisers of celebrations in Washington on Saturday said they were adding water stations along with cooling resources and medical support.

'Deaths surged 29% in France during week of record heat'

PARIS: Deaths surged by nearly a third in France during the hottest week of a record heat wave last month, the country's public health authority said Friday, reporting at least 2,000 more deaths than in the previous week when temperatures were already climbing and filling emergency wards with heat victims.

The new and still incomplete figures from Public Health France doubled its first preliminary estimate of at least 1,000 additional deaths that it gave last Sunday. That earlier estimate covered just three of the hottest days of extreme, deadly heat.

In Paris, funeral service directors have said they've struggled to find places to store bodies before burial or cremation, with some mortuaries saying they were full and having to turn bodies away.

Adani Enterprises upsizes QIP to ₹15K cr amid 3.8x demand

It drew strong interest from Capital Group, Goldman Sachs, BlackRock, Blackstone & Nomura

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Billionaire Gautam Adani-led group's flagship firm has increased the size of its Qualified Institutional Placement (QIP) to Rs 15,000 crore from the planned Rs 10,000 crore after the share sale attracted bids worth about Rs 38,000 crore, or 3.8 times the original issue size, according to people familiar with the transaction.

Adani Enterprises Ltd's (AEL) offering, launched on Thursday, was subscribed about 3.8 times the original base issue size, with demand led primarily by long-only institutional investors, they said.

It drew strong interest from long-only institutional investors, with participation from global asset managers including Capital Group, Goldman Sachs, BlackRock, Blackstone and Nomura.

Domestic investors included HDFC Mutual Fund, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Kotak Mutual Fund, Aditya Birla Sun Life Mutual Fund, SBI Mutual Fund and Tata Mutual Fund.

The book was fully covered within 48 hours of the roadshow, ahead of the formal launch, prompting the company to exercise an upsized option, the people said. Several investors sought allocations larger than they ultimately received, reflecting strong institutional demand.

The fundraising comes as investors assess ongoing legal proceedings in the US involving



ing Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani. Last week, a US federal judge declined to immediately dismiss criminal charges against Adani and asked the Department of Justice to provide additional justification for its decision to seek dismissal of the case. Despite the legal backdrop, institutional participation in the QIP remained robust.

The issue marks AEL's second major equity fundraising in the past year, following its Rs 25,000 crore rights issue completed in 2024. According to the company, proceeds from the QIP will be used to fund capital expenditure across its incubation businesses, repay debt and pursue strategic investments and acquisitions.

The fundraising follows the company's announcement this week of an \$11.5 billion (about Rs 1.1 lakh crore) aluminium manufacturing venture with Abu Dhabi-based IHC.

The indicative issue price was set at Rs 2,883 per share, representing a 5 per cent discount to the SEBI floor price of Rs 3,034.68 and a 9.3 per cent discount to the stock's July 2 closing price of Rs 3,177.50.

Jefferies, SBI Capital Markets, ICICI Securities and IIFL Securities are managing the offering.

Manipal Health gets SEBI nod for July IPO

HYDERABAD/BENGALURU: India's Manipal Health Enterprises, backed by Singapore's Temasek, has received approval for its stock market listing from market regulator SEBI, two sources familiar with the matter told Reuters on Friday.

The hospital chain is targeting a market debut in late July or early August, said the sources, who asked not to be named as the information has not yet been made public. The offering is expected to be one of the largest IPOs by an Indian healthcare company.

Manipal filed for an initial public offering of up to \$1.2 billion in March, betting on rising demand for complex care.

The listing comes as Iran war-driven geopolitical risks have fuelled a record selloff by foreign investors, which led to a slowdown in the IPO market as companies take a more cautious approach.

Overseas investors have offloaded \$29.2 billion worth of shares so far this year, pushing the benchmark Nifty 50 index down about 7 per cent. AGENCIES

LME clears Adani copper brand for delivery

LONDON: The London Metal Exchange (LME) has approved the Adani Copper brand for delivery against its copper contracts, the exchange said on Friday.

Warrants for the brand can be issued from July 10, although the LME-registered warehouses holding Adani Copper metal must include the brand in their off-warrant stock reports with immediate effect, the exchange added.

The brand is produced by Adani Enterprises-owned Kutch Copper, one of India's largest copper smelters, with annual production capacity of 500,000 metric tons, Reuters reported.

The company applied for London Metal Exchange registration in August 2025.

According to Adani, this \$1.2 billion Kutch Copper facility in the western state of Gujarat is the world's biggest single-location plant of its type, expected to reduce India's reliance on imported copper.

India imported 238,080 tons of refined copper in 2025, down 18 per cent from a year earlier, according to Trade Data Monitor data, with Japan remaining the country's largest supplier. AGENCIES

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E. Tender Notice No. JHS/Br/L/2026-27/07 Date : 29.06.2026
E-Tendering Tender Notice
By, Chief Engineer/Bridge/Line/Jhansi, North Central Railway, Jhansi for and on behalf of President of India invites open E-tenders on the prescribed forms for the under noted work :

Tender no.: Br-JHS-2026-07	Approx Cost of work : Rs. 1,51,80,519.3/-
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Name of work : Repair of various ROB's and provision of ladder, inspection platform in ROB's over Jhansi Division under Dy.CE/Br/L/JHS.
Bid Security (Earnest Money): Rs. 3,03,600.00/- **Completion period:** 10 Months
Date of closing of Tender : 21.07.2026, **Eligibility Criteria for similar work :** "Any civil engineering work". **Note :** (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website **www.ireps.gov.in.** up to 15:00 hrs. on the due to date of tender closing i.e. **21.07.2026.** (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose; vendors are required to get themselves registered with **IREPS** website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act 2000. (3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/Letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightway ignored and shall not be considered. (4) Document being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. (5) Payment of Bid Security (Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)) in respect of e-tendering shall be accepted through net banking or payment gateway or bank guarantee only. (6) In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of **IREPS** may be approached. (7) Tender on line can be submitted up to 15.00 hrs. on dated **21.07.2026.** 1490/26 (ADM)

MADHYA PRADESH URBAN DEVELOPMENT COMPANY LIMITED
(Government of Madhya Pradesh)
(Under Urban Development & Housing Department GoMP)
Amarkantak Bhavan Indira Press Complex, M.P. Nagar Zone 1, Bhopal, Tel : +91-755-2763060,61,62, Fax : +91-755-2763868
E-mail : mpusipbpl@mpurban.gov.in
NIT No. - MPUDC/ENGG/2026/8370 **Date : 02.07.2026**

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS

Section-1
Online percentage rate bid on "Tender Document Appendix 2.10" for the following works to be executed under "MPUDC" are invited from registered contractors and firms of reputed fulfilling eligibility criteria:

S. No.	Online Tender No.	Work	Probable Amount (In lacs)	Completion Period (Months)
1	MPUDC/	Construction of Fire Station work for Municipal Corporation Burhanpur of Madhya Pradesh.	159.41	06 Months including rainy season

- Interested Bidder can view the NIT on website <http://www.mptender.gov.in> and www.mpurban.gov.in
- The Bid Document can be purchased only Online from **10:00 AM 03.07.2026 to 15:00 PM 06.08.2026.**
- Any clarification/further information or addenda to the NIT, if any, would be published on website only, and not in Newspaper.

126717/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
T. Notice No. : 230-Elect/TRD/PRYJ/E-Tender Notice/2026/643 Date: 01.07.2026
E-TENDER NOTICE
Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer/TRD/N.C. Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following E-Tender, the details of the tenders are as under:-
T. No.: 230-TRD- WC-1032-2026
Description of work : 25kV OHE modification work due to construction of RUB at L.C-13 in Bharwari yard & CTR(S) works in Prayagraj Division.

Advertised value: Rs. 82.79,536.52	Bid Security: Rs. 1,65,600.00
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Completion Period: 12 Months **Bidding system:** Single Packet
Tender Closing date & Time: 23.07.2026 & 14:00 Hrs
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NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Notice No. AGC-EL-GSU/Mis/12 Date: 02.07.2026
"PUBLIC NOTIFICATION"
The following substitution will be Energized.
Name of Substation with its location: Energization of 11/0.415 KV equipment comprising of 2 x 500 KVA Transformer of Electric substation in connection with upgradation and improvement of Goods shed at Mathura station of Agra division.
Energisation date of Substation : 12.07.2026
Dy.CEE/GSU
1511/26(ADM) North Central Railway, Agra

GOVERNMENT OF PUNJAB
GREATER MOHALI AREA DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
PUDA BHAWAN, SECTOR 62, SAS NAGAR
Tender Notice No. 1346-1349 Dated 03-07-2026
Divisional Engineer (Electrical), GMADA, SAS Nagar invites online bids for

- Providing compact sub stations at Commercial Pocket A, B and C of Sector 78 at SAS Nagar.
- Dismantling of existing LT lines and providing underground cable for making alternate connectivity to clear site earmarked for Currency Chest Site Sector 79 at SAS Nagar.

Closing date & time: 20-07-2026 at 12:00 Noon for work mentioned at sr. no. 1
15-07-2026 at 12:00 Noon for work mentioned at sr. no. 2
For details log on to: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>
Note: Any corrigendum(s) to the tender notice shall be published on the above website only.
RO No PR-Adv. No :-1324/12/2026-27/12973

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
T. Notice No. : 230-Elect/TRD/PRYJ/E-Tender Notice/2026/643 Date: 01.07.2026
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ICICI Bank
Regd. Office: ICICI Bank Limited, Landmark, Race Course Circle, Vadodra- 390007
Corporate Office: ICICI Bank Towers, Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai- 400051
Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd., Sha Tower, Plot No 23, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, Delhi- 110005
Notice for Disclosure of Legal Heirs of Deceased Borrower
PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that Home Loan LBNOD00003067507 (Credit facility) was granted to LATA RANI along with the deceased GAGAN GAUTAM by ICICI Bank Ltd. (The Bank). We would like to inform you that the demise of GAGAN GAUTAM has come to our knowledge during field visits conducted by the Bank officials and by telephonic communications on the registered contact numbers. In this regard, letter dated JULY 02, 2026, was previously sent to the registered addresses of the Borrowers and the Deceased GAGAN GAUTAM, for providing information about the Legal Heirs of the Deceased Borrower. Therefore, this Notice is hereby given for sharing details of the Legal Heirs of the deceased GAGAN GAUTAM with supporting documents for updating the Bank's records, within 15 days of publication of this Notice. You may submit the above-mentioned details to Mr. UDAY SHANKAR by visiting ICICI BANK LTD BLOCK C-1, 19TH FLOOR WORLD TRADE TOWER, SECTOR-16 UTTAR PRADESH NOIDA 201301.
Date : July 04, 2026 Authorised Officer
Place : Delhi/Ncr For ICICI Bank Ltd,

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PITCHES INVESTMENT OPPORTUNITIES

FM invites French firms to partner in Viksit Bharat 2047

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman invited French businesses and investors to partner with India in its journey towards Viksit Bharat 2047, emphasising the need to strengthen the India-France Strategic Partnership and work towards shared prosperity for both countries.

Addressing an India-France Business Roundtable in Paris on Thursday, she urged French investors to explore partnerships in healthcare, pharmaceuticals and biotechnology by leveraging the two countries' complementary strengths in life sciences, vaccines, active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs), clinical research, precision medicine and digital health to build resilient healthcare value chains.

The minister also highlighted India's clean energy transition, including the target of achieving 500 GW of non-fossil fuel capacity by 2030, the National Green Hydrogen Mission and Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes, saying these initiatives offer significant investment opportunities in renewable energy, green hydrogen, battery storage, offshore wind and smart grids, the finance ministry said in a post on X.

Pitching India's financial ecosystem, Sitharaman said



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

She urged French investors to explore partnerships in healthcare, pharma and biotechnology by leveraging the two nations' complementary strengths

the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) has emerged as a leading global financial hub, with over 1,200 registered entities as of June 2026, banking assets of \$111 billion and cumulative banking transactions worth \$176 billion.

She said opportunities are expanding across banking, fund management, leasing, Global Capability Centres (GCCs), reinsurance and sus-

Highlights

- » She also highlighted India's clean energy transition, including the target of achieving 500 GW of non-fossil fuel capacity by 2030
- » She said opportunities are expanding across banking, fund management, leasing, Global Capability Centres (GCCs), reinsurance and sustainable finance
- » 'India's Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) such as Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, ONDC and India Stack, accounts for nearly half of world's real-time digital payments'

tainable finance.

She also highlighted the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF), saying its proposed \$3.5 billion Infrastructure Fund II and \$1 billion Private Markets Fund II offer long-term investment opportunities across infrastructure, digital infrastructure, green hydrogen, energy transition and other high-growth sectors. Stressing that India-France bilateral trade has doubled in

the past decade, she said the evolving global economic landscape, shaped by technological transformation, supply chain diversification, energy transition and geopolitical developments, presents new opportunities for stronger bilateral collaboration.

She said India and France are trusted partners in shaping the global artificial intelligence ecosystem and can expand cooperation in trusted AI, digital infrastructure and next-generation technologies.

Sitharaman said India's digital economy, powered by Digital Public Infrastructure such as Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker, ONDC and India Stack, accounts for nearly half of the world's real-time digital payments.

There are approximately 1,000 French companies operating in India.

During the roundtable, representatives of leading French financial institutions outlined their existing business and investment engagements in India and acknowledged the country's economic reforms over the past decade, including efforts to reduce compliance burdens and improve the ease of doing business.

They also shared suggestions for expanding long-term investment cooperation between the two countries.

Centre says ethanol blending programme backed by global practice, scientific studies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government on Friday issued a detailed rebuttal to what it described as misinformation circulating on social media about the country's E20 ethanol blending programme, rejecting claims ranging from excessive water consumption and engine damage to insurance invalidation and environmental harm.

In a 10-point clarification, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said the programme, under which petrol contains up to 20 per cent ethanol, is supported by scientific studies, international experience and regulatory safeguards.

Rejecting claims that producing one litre of ethanol consumes 10,000 litres of water, the ministry said only surplus rice, cleared after meeting national food security requirements, is diverted for ethanol production.

It added that ethanol distilleries consume about 3-5 litres of processed water per litre of ethanol and increasingly operate Zero Liquid Discharge systems to recycle water.

The ministry also said maize, which now accounts for more than 40 per cent of ethanol supplied under the programme, requires significantly lower irrigation than paddy and is being promoted through higher minimum support prices.

The government also dismissed assertions that E20 is an untested fuel, noting that ethanol-blended fuels have been used internationally for decades. It cited countries, including the



The ministry said ethanol distilleries consume about 3-5 litres of processed water/litre of ethanol & increasingly operate Zero Liquid Discharge systems to recycle water

United States, Brazil, Canada, Thailand, Japan and several European nations, as having adopted ethanol blending at varying levels.

Addressing concerns over vehicle performance, the ministry said Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI)-led trials covering about 40,000 kilometres in passenger cars and 20,000 kilometres in two-wheelers found no significant adverse impact on drivability or fuel efficiency, with only "marginal" changes in mileage.

It added that vehicles calibrated for E20 could benefit from ethanol's higher octane rating.

On allegations that E20 damages engines or corrodes

components, the ministry cited studies conducted by ARAI in collaboration with Indian Oil Corporation, the Indian Institute of Petroleum and the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers.

The studies found no issues relating to drivability or compatibility of metal and plastic components, although certain rubber parts in older vehicles may require earlier replacement.

The ministry also rejected claims that the use of E20 fuel could void vehicle warranties or insurance coverage, saying automobile manufacturers and insurers have clarified that vehicles designed or approved for E20 remain covered under applicable warranty and insurance terms.

Responding to viral social media posts suggesting ants and bees are attracted to E20 fuel because it contains sugar, the ministry said fuel-grade ethanol undergoes distillation that removes residual sugars and contains denaturants that repel insects. It also said petrol's hydrocarbon odour dominates the blended fuel.

The government further denied claims that it had described the E20 programme as an "experiment" before the Supreme Court, saying the court proceedings related to contractual provisions governing ethanol procurement rather than the merits of the blending programme.

It cited a clarification issued by the Office of the Attorney General stating that media reports suggesting otherwise

were inaccurate. The ministry also dismissed claims that E20 allows water to enter vehicle fuel tanks, saying modern vehicles and fuel retail infrastructure are equipped with safeguards to prevent water ingress.

It similarly described viral videos purporting to show sugarcane juice being mixed into petrol as fabricated, saying fuel ethanol is manufactured through industrial processes and blended according to prescribed quality specifications.

On environmental concerns, the government said ethanol plants require statutory environmental clearances, must comply with groundwater regulations and are required to operate Zero Liquid Discharge systems.

It added that the programme has contributed to foreign exchange savings of more than Rs 1.9 lakh crore, expedited payments exceeding Rs 1.6 lakh crore to farmers, reduced carbon dioxide emissions by around 930 lakh metric tonnes and displaced over 310 lakh metric tonnes of crude oil imports since 2014-15.

India achieved its target of 20 per cent ethanol blending in petrol in December 2025, ahead of schedule, after blending levels rose from about 1.5 per cent in 2013-14, according to the ministry. It said installed ethanol production capacity has reached about 2,000 crore litres, with procurement projected to exceed 1,200 crore litres during the 2025-26 ethanol supply year.

Forex stocks fall \$5.654 bn to \$666.933 bn



MUMBAI: India's forex reserves dropped \$5.654 billion to \$666.933 billion during the week ended June 26, the RBI said on Friday.

The kitty had expanded to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year before the onset of the West Asia conflict, which led to several weeks of a drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales.

For the week ended June 26, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, decreased \$150 million to \$541.067 billion, the central bank's data showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in foreign exchange reserves.

Value of gold reserves declined \$5.394 billion to \$102.536 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The special drawing rights (SDRs) were down by \$89 million at \$18.558 billion, the apex bank said.

India's reserve position with the IMF was also down \$21 million to \$4.772 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the apex bank's data.

Stock markets extend winning run to third day, Sensex rises 262 pts on rally in IT stocks

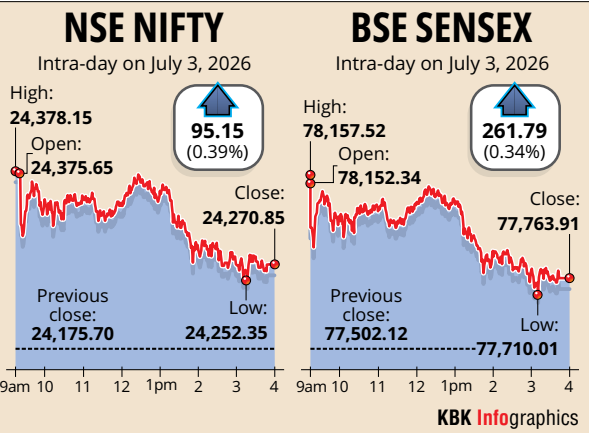
The rupee appreciates by 17 paise to close at 95.18 against the US dollar

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty ended higher on Friday, extending their winning momentum to the third day running, amid a rally in IT stocks and a softer-than-expected US jobs data tempering expectations of near-term monetary tightening by the Federal Reserve.

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 261.79 points, or 0.34 per cent, to settle at 77,763.91.

The 50-share NSE Nifty went up 95.15 points, or 0.39 per cent, to end at 24,270.85.

From the Sensex pack, HCL Tech surged 5.79 per cent, followed by Tech Mahindra which climbed 1.81 per cent. Bharti Airtel, Sun Pharma, Bajaj Finserv, UltraTech Cement, Tata



Steel Bajaj Finance, Tata Consultancy Services, and ICICI Bank were also among the winners. Axis Bank, SBI, Mahindra

& Mahindra, and L&T were among the laggards. Sectorally, realty surged 2.22 per cent, focused IT jumped

1.74 per cent, IT (1.55 per cent), healthcare (1.31 per cent), commodities (0.90 per cent), metal (0.89 per cent) and telecommunication (0.77 per cent). Power declined 2.39 per cent, capital goods (2.26 per cent), industrials (1.45 per cent), utilities (0.58 per cent), auto (0.42 per cent) and consumer durables (0.32 per cent).

A total of 2,257 stocks advanced, while 1,986 declined and 198 remained unchanged on the BSE. The rupee appreciated 17 paise to close at 95.18 against the US dollar on Friday as the dollar index retreated from its recent 15-month high levels and mirrored positive domestic equities.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



REC Ltd has sanctioned Rs 4.22 crore for the project, 'Establishing 100 Smart Classrooms in 100 Government Schools in the Lakhimpur and Kaziranga regions of Assam.' A Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) for the project was signed on July 2, 2026, at REC Limited's Corporate Office in Gurugram between L B Nautiyal, HoD (CSR), REC Ltd & B Vinod Kumar, Director, Indo German Institute of Advanced Technology (IGIAT). The signing ceremony was held in the presence of Arun Kumar Tyagi, Executive Director (CSR), REC Ltd, and other officials from REC Ltd and IGIAT.

Indian Potash Ltd, UPL SAS partner to enhance sugarcane productivity

NEW DELHI: UPL Sustainable Agri Solutions Ltd (UPL SAS) and Indian Potash Ltd (IPL) have entered into a three-year collaboration agreement to enhance sugarcane productivity, sustainability, and farmer prosperity in the catchment area of IPL's Kodinar Sugar Mill in Gujarat.

The partnership aims to implement regenerative agriculture practices, advanced agronomy, crop protection, nutrition management, digitalization, and farmer capacity-building initiatives across approximately 2,000 acres of sugarcane cultivation.

The program is expected to improve sugarcane yields by a minimum of 15 percent, while



supporting resource efficiency, profitability, and climate-smart agricultural practices.

Under the agreement, UPL SAS will deploy a dedicated Program Officer to lead field-level implementation and farmer engagement activities.

The initiative will focus on optimizing key agricultural resources including seed, soil, water, fertilizer use, and crop residue management while promoting sustainable crop protection and nutrition solutions tailored to local conditions.

As part of this initiative,

ACE & Japan-based KATO Works form JV firm ACE KATO Pvt Ltd

The 50:50 JV company will manufacture high-capacity cranes in India for domestic and global markets

NEW DELHI: Action Construction Equipment (ACE) and Japan's KATO Works have formed a 50:50 joint venture, ACE KATO Pvt. Ltd., to manufacture high-capacity cranes in India for domestic and global markets.

The venture will produce truck cranes, crawler cranes and rough terrain cranes for sectors including infrastructure, mining, ports, energy, metro rail and heavy industry.

The company has set up an 11-acre manufacturing facility in Haryana with a planned investment of around Rs 200 crore. The investment will support manufacturing infrastructure, technology integration, advanced production systems and product development, with further investments planned to expand capacity.

Under the partnership, KATO will lead product engineering, design and technol-

ogy, while ACE will handle manufacturing, sourcing and localisation. The companies aim to progressively increase local sourcing through ACE's supplier network to improve efficiency, reduce costs and strengthen supply-chain resilience while maintaining KATO's quality and safety standards. The initiative also supports the vision of manufacturing cranes in India for global markets.

Gold reclaims ₹1.5L/10 gm mark, rises by ₹3,300

NEW DELHI: Gold prices reclaimed the Rs 1.5 lakh per 10 grams mark in the national capital on Friday, gaining Rs 3,300 in the second straight session, as a strong global trend and a weaker US dollar boosted bullion demand.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity increased Rs 3,300, or 2.2 per cent, to Rs 1,50,800 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from Thursday's closing level of Rs 1,47,500 per 10 grams.

Silver also advanced for the fourth consecutive session, rising Rs 5,000, or 2.08 per cent, to Rs 2,45,000 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes).



The white metal had closed at Rs 2,40,000 per kg in the previous session.

In the international markets, spot gold gained \$57.58, or 1.4 per cent, to \$4,181.50 per ounce and silver rose 2.44 per cent to \$62.45 per ounce.

PSPCL increases power supply to agricultural feeders across state

PATIALA: The Punjab State Power Corporation Limited (PSPCL) has increased electricity supply to agricultural feeders across the state, with some receiving up to 20 hours of power, to compensate farmers for a temporary shortfall in supply during the last week of June.

PSPCL Chairman-cum-Managing Director Basant Garg said the enhanced supply is being provided on the directions of Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and Power Minister Tarunpreet Singh Sond. He said the state's power situation has returned to normal and adequate arrangements are in place

to meet electricity demand during the ongoing paddy season.

Garg said some agricultural feeders received only six to seven hours of electricity instead of the scheduled eight hours between June 27 and June 30. The disruption was caused by record power demand during the heatwave and a strike by contractual workers at thermal power plants, which affected generation.

Despite the challenges, PSPCL ensured six to seven hours of supply by operating its system round the clock. Following the end of the strike and restoration of thermal power

generation, normal supply has resumed and additional electricity is being provided to affected feeders. He said the government has decided that farmers should not suffer due to exceptional circumstances and has directed PSPCL to compensate them with extra power.

Special operational measures have also been put in place during the paddy season. Field officers have been asked to closely monitor feeder-wise supply, optimise power availability and promptly resolve local issues to ensure uninterrupted irrigation and reliable electricity across the state.



AAMIR KHAN TO MARRY GAURI SPRATT ON JULY 5 AT HIS MUMBAI HOME

The ‘Lagaan’ actor is tying the knot for the third time

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Finally, the date has been revealed. Yes, we are talking about the much-discussed Aamir Khan’s third wedding. The Bollywood superstar has confirmed that he will tie the knot with his girlfriend Gauri Spratt at his Mumbai house on July 5.

At the special screening of Rajkumar Hirani’s web series, ‘Pritam and Pedro’ in Mumbai, the ‘Lagaan’ actor said that the wedding would be an ‘intimate and small affair’ only to be attended by close family members and friends. With ‘Pritam and Pedro’, Hirani has finally stepped into the world of web series.

“The wedding is on July 5. We are hosting it at home... It’s a very small, intimate affair. It is a very special day for us. Both families and a few close



“We are hosting it at home... It’s a very small, intimate affair. It is a very special day for us”

—Aamir Khan

friends will be there. We just need everyone’s blessings for our happiness and pray that we have a wonderful journey ahead,” the ‘3 Idiots’ actor said. He was accompanied by

his son, Junaid Khan, at the event.

The ‘PK’ actor introduced Spratt to the media in March 2025 and publicly confirmed his relationship during celebrations for his 60th birthday. Since then, the couple has been spotted several times together. The actor had shared that they have known each other for 25 years but started dating recently. Hailing from Bengaluru, Spratt has a son from her previous relationship.

Meanwhile, this is the third marriage of the ‘Dangal’ actor. He has been married to Reena Dutta and has two kids, Junaid and Ira, with her. Later in 2005, Khan married filmmaker Kiran Rao. In 2021, they announced their separation. However, the couple continue to co-parent their son, Azad. The guest list of Khan’s third wedding will include his former wives and three children.

Netflix launches NextGen India Writers’ Program



It is open to writers with up to three years of professional writing experience

Streaming service ‘Netflix’ announced the launch of the NextGen India Writers’ Program, a talent development initiative aimed at identifying and mentoring emerging screenwriters in the country. The programme, being introduced in India for the first time, is open to writers with up to three years of professional writing experience.



Monika Shergill, vice president of content at ‘Netflix India’, said the initiative is aimed at discovering and nurturing new storytelling talent

India is the third country after France and the Netherlands to host the initiative, the streamer said in a statement.

Selected participants will undergo a two-month hybrid programme featuring mentorship, workshops and guidance from industry experts to develop original series ideas into professionally structured series bibles.

Monika Shergill, vice president of content at ‘Netflix India’, said the initiative is aimed at discovering and nurturing new storytelling talent.

“Every great story begins with a writer. In a country as creatively rich and diverse as India, we know there are countless people with extraordinary stories to tell who simply haven’t had the opportunity yet. The Netflix NextGen India Writers’ Program is our way of discovering those voices early, investing in their potential

and giving them the space to develop their craft and bring their stories to life,” Shergill said.

She said ‘Netflix’ believes the next phase of Indian entertainment will be driven by storytellers with fresh perspectives and distinctive voices.

According to the streamer, the programme will help participants understand the process of developing an original idea into a long-form series for the screen.

PTI

Akash recalls Rajkummar’s surprise call after watching ‘Raakh’



OUR CORRESPONDENT

Raakh, the gritty crime drama that has struck a chord with audiences, features Akash Makhija and Ramandeep Yadav in breakout performances that have earned them the ‘IMDb’ ‘Breakout Star’ STARmeter Awards. In an exclusive interaction with ‘IMDb’, the duo reflected on the journeys that led them to acting, the projects they wish more audiences would discover and the memorable appreciation they received following the success of the series.

Recalling the moment that first inspired him to pursue acting, Makhija shared that it all began with an iconic comedy character. “When ‘Hera Pheri’ came out, I was absolutely captivated, perhaps even obsessed, by Paresh Rawal’s character, Baburao. I used to mimic him every single day. I even declared at home that I would become an actor. It’s funny to think that it all started with that Baburao character and now, here I am, having played the role of Babu.”

Yadav, on the other hand, revealed that acting was never part of his original plan. “My initial plan was actually to pursue sports. I was into cricket and it never even crossed my wildest dreams that I’d enter the

The gritty crime drama features Akash Makhija and Ramandeep Yadav in breakout performances

entertainment industry or take up acting. I wanted to represent India.”

“Arshdeep is my batchmate and friend and Vaibhav Arora, who plays for KKR, is also a friend of mine. But sometimes things just don’t work out. Perhaps God had something else in store for you,” he added.

Speaking about his acting journey, Ramandeep said, “I ventured into acting after college and did theatre in Chandigarh for seven or eight years, while continuing to audition. My first role was a small part in Anurag Kashyap’s ‘Manmarziyaan’.

The actors also highlighted some of their earlier work that they believe deserves more attention.

Sharing one of the most memorable reactions he received for ‘Raakh’, Makhija revealed that actor Rajkummar Rao personally reached out to him after watching the series. “I received a message from Rajkummar Rao on Instagram asking me to send him my number. He called me and said, ‘You guys have no idea what you’ve done.’”

‘Was looking forward to play an antagonist after a long time’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Actor Sanjay Kapoor, who currently stars in Amazon MX Player’s much-talked-about series ‘Ab Hoga Hisaab’, reflected on his journey with the series and stepping into the shoes of Goldy Sekhon.

“It was a lot of fun shooting with the cast. There is a character called Raathi in the series, played by a terrific actor and I have some very interesting scenes with him. While Raathi is a grey character himself, the way Goldy manipulates him adds a very intriguing layer to the story. Even before I signed the project, I knew we had a fantastic ensemble cast, which was exciting. What drew me in even more was Goldy. Playing an antagonist after a long time was something I was really looking forward to,” said Kapoor.

Speaking about the camaraderie

Sanjay Kapoor stepped into the shoes of Goldy Sekhon in ‘Ab Hoga Hisaab’

on set and filming across locations, he added, “We began shooting in Mumbai in October before moving to Patiala in November and December, where most of the series was filmed. Patiala was lovely and what made the experience even more special was the bond we shared as a cast. Mouni has this wonderful ability to bring everyone together, so whenever we had free time, we would all hang out and spend time together. Even though it was my first time working with most of them, it never felt like it.”



Jodie thinks ‘F1’ was made with AI

Hollywood star Jodie Foster is convinced Brad Pitt’s film ‘F1’ was made with artificial intelligence. The film released on June 27, 2025. It was directed by Joseph Kosinski and revolved around Pitt’s Sonny Hayes, a former Formula One racer from the 1990s who comes out of retirement following a career-ending crash.

The actress attended the ‘Who Owns the Future of Hollywood’ discussion, where she spoke with former Sony Pictures’ CEO Michael Lynton at the ‘Aspen Festival of Ideas’. During the conversation, Foster said the film appeared structured and written formulaically.

“I don’t say this disparagingly. How could I? This movie went on to make millions of dollars. But I look at a movie like ‘F1’ and I’m like, ‘F1 was made by AI.’”

PTI



She has made a comeback to the genre in ‘Welcome to the Jungle’

RAVEENA ON MAKING PEOPLE LAUGH WITHOUT OFFENDING

‘IT IS VERY TOUGH’

Raveena Tandon said humour in the 1990s was uninhibited and unapologetic

Raveena Tandon said humour in the 1990s was uninhibited and unapologetic, something that is difficult to replicate in movies today, as one never knows what will trigger a social media debate.

The actress credits comedy hits like ‘Bade Miyan Chote Miyan’, ‘Aunty No. 1’, ‘Dulhe Raja’, ‘Pardesi Babu’, ‘Aakhion Se Goli Maare’ and many more as the backbone of her career in Bollywood. But she believes the landscape has changed drastically over the years.

“Making people laugh without someone getting offended is probably the ultimate tightrope walk today; it is tough. In the 1990s, there was an uninhibited, innocent and totally unapologetic madness to our films. Chi Chi (Govinda) and I would react purely to instinct. We weren’t overthinking how a joke would look on a 15-second internet clip or if a line would trigger a social media debate,” Tandon told PTI in an interview.

She added, “That raw, purely

character-driven, loud-and-proud humour of the 1990s is rare now because filmmakers are constantly second-guessing themselves. We’ve become a bit too cautious and comedy desperately needs freedom to breathe.”

The actress has made a comeback to the genre in ‘Welcome to the Jungle’, a multi-starrer comedy that reunites Tandon with her 1990s ‘Mohrra’ co-stars Akshay Kumar and Suniel Shetty.

“Comedy taught me spontaneity, improvisation and the importance of losing all inhibitions on screen. It is an incredibly giving genre; if you can successfully make people laugh, they keep you in their hearts forever. Returning to it now with ‘Welcome to the Jungle’ feels like coming home to a room full of old friends,” she said.

She added, “Comedy has honestly been the backbone of my commercial identity. While intense, dramatic roles like ‘Daman’ or ‘Satta’ gave me critical validation and the National Award, it was comedy that built my deep connection with the masses. Even today, kids who weren’t even born in the 90s know me because of those loops on television and social media.”

AGENCIES

